

**GLOBAL WEALTH UNIVERSITY, LOME, TOGO
DEPARTMENT OF INTERNATIONAL
RELATIONS AND DIPLOMACY**

**CHINA'S ROLES IN AFRICA; INVESTMENT, DIPLOMACY
AND STRATEGIC INFLUENCE**

BY

ASIYANBOLA OYINDAMOLA SOFIAT

MATRIC NO: 160096

**A PROJECT SUBMITTED IN PARTIAL FULFILLMENT OF THE REQUIREMENTS FOR THE AWARD OF
BACHELOR OF SCIENCE (B.sc) IN INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AND DIPLOMACY**

2026

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2026

CERTIFICATION

This is to certify that this research project titled “China’s Roles in Africa: Investment, Diplomacy and Strategic Influence” was carried out by _____

Matriculation Number: _____ in the Department of International Relations and Diplomacy, Global Wealth University Lome, Togo.

This project has been read, supervised, and approved as meeting the requirements for the award of the degree of _____.

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Head of Department

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Date: _____

External Examiner

Name: _____

Signature: _____

Date: _____

DEDICATION

This research work is dedicated to my parents, whose unwavering support, sacrifices, and encouragement made my academic journey possible. I also dedicate this work to all African youths and scholars who aspire to contribute meaningfully to the development of Africa through knowledge, research, and informed policy engagement.

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ABSTRACT

In recent decades, the relationship between China and Africa has experienced a significant transformation, evolving into one of the most influential international partnerships in the contemporary global system. China's growing presence across African countries has attracted widespread scholarly, political, and public attention, largely due to the scale of its investments, its distinctive diplomatic approach, and its expanding strategic influence on the continent. This study examines China's roles in Africa with particular emphasis on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, and evaluates the implications of these engagements for Africa's economic development, political autonomy, and long-term sustainability.

The rapid expansion of China–Africa relations has generated mixed reactions. On one hand, China is often portrayed as a development partner that provides critical infrastructure, financial assistance, and trade opportunities to African nations that have long faced challenges such as underdevelopment, poor infrastructure, and limited access to global capital markets. On the other hand, critics argue that China's involvement may lead to excessive debt burdens, resource exploitation, weak environmental standards, and new forms of dependency. Against this background, this study seeks to provide a balanced and comprehensive assessment of China's engagement in Africa, highlighting both the opportunities and challenges associated with this growing partnership.

The primary objective of this study is to examine the nature, scope, and impact of China's involvement in Africa across three major dimensions: economic investment, diplomatic relations, and strategic influence. Specifically, the study aims to assess the contribution of Chinese investments to Africa's economic growth and infrastructure development; analyze China's diplomatic strategies and their influence on Africa's foreign policy orientations; and evaluate the extent to which China has expanded its strategic presence in Africa through trade, security cooperation, technology transfer, cultural exchange, and soft power initiatives. In addition, the study seeks to identify the key challenges and risks associated with China–Africa relations and propose strategies through which African countries can maximize the benefits of engagement with China while minimizing potential negative outcomes.

The study adopts a descriptive and analytical research design, relying primarily on secondary data sources. Data were obtained from academic journals, textbooks, government publications, policy briefs, reports from international organizations such as the World Bank, International Monetary Fund (IMF), United Nations, and African Union, as well as publications from Chinese and African research institutions. Content analysis was used to examine trends, patterns, and key themes in

China–Africa relations, while comparative analysis helped to highlight differences in China’s engagement across various African regions and sectors. This methodological approach allows for a broad and in-depth understanding of China’s roles in Africa without relying on primary field data.

Findings from the study reveal that Chinese investment has played a significant role in addressing Africa’s infrastructure deficit, particularly in sectors such as transportation, energy, telecommunications, mining, and construction. Chinese-funded projects, including roads, railways, ports, power plants, and industrial parks, have contributed to improved connectivity, increased productivity, and enhanced regional integration in many African countries. The study also finds that China has become one of Africa’s largest trading partners and a major source of foreign direct investment (FDI), offering alternative financing options that differ from traditional Western development assistance models.

In terms of diplomacy, the study finds that China’s engagement with Africa is largely guided by principles of non-interference, mutual respect for sovereignty, and win-win cooperation. Through platforms such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC), China has institutionalized its diplomatic relations with African states and provided a framework for political dialogue, economic cooperation, and development assistance. This diplomatic approach has strengthened China’s political ties with African countries and increased Africa’s bargaining power in the global arena. However, the study also notes concerns that China’s non-conditional aid and loans may weaken governance reforms and accountability mechanisms in some African states.

The study further reveals that China’s strategic influence in Africa extends beyond economics and diplomacy to include security cooperation, education, culture, media, and technology. China has expanded its soft power through scholarship programs, Confucius Institutes, cultural exchanges, media partnerships, and training programs for African professionals and government officials. In

addition, China's involvement in peacekeeping operations, military training, and security infrastructure highlights its growing strategic interest in Africa's stability and security. These initiatives have enhanced China's image as a global power and strengthened its long-term strategic presence on the continent.

Despite the numerous benefits associated with China's engagement in Africa, the study identifies several challenges and risks. These include rising debt levels in some African countries, concerns over transparency and loan terms, limited technology transfer, weak local content participation, environmental degradation, and labor-related issues. The study also highlights fears that Africa may become overly dependent on China for financing, trade, and infrastructure development if adequate diversification strategies are not adopted. These challenges underscore the need for African governments to adopt proactive policies that protect national interests while engaging constructively with China.

The study concludes that China's roles in Africa are complex and multifaceted, characterized by both developmental opportunities and strategic concerns. While China has contributed significantly to Africa's economic transformation and global integration, the long-term impact of this engagement largely depends on the policies, governance structures, and negotiation capacities of African states. The study emphasizes that China–Africa relations should not be viewed as inherently beneficial or harmful, but rather as a partnership that requires careful management, transparency, and mutual accountability.

Based on the findings, the study recommends that African countries strengthen institutional capacity, improve debt management practices, enhance transparency in investment agreements, and prioritize projects that support sustainable development and local capacity building. It also recommends that African governments diversify their international partnerships while engaging China strategically to ensure balanced and inclusive development outcomes. Ultimately, the study contributes to existing literature by providing a nuanced understanding of China's roles in Africa and offers policy-relevant insights for scholars, policymakers, and development practitioners interested in Africa's evolving global partnerships.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

AU – African Union

BRI – Belt and Road Initiative

FOCAC – Forum on China–Africa Cooperation

FDI – Foreign Direct Investment

GDP – Gross Domestic Product

IMF – International Monetary Fund

OECD – Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development

UN – United Nations

UNDP – United Nations Development Programme

UNCTAD – United Nations Conference on Trade and Development

WB – World Bank

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

In recent decades, Africa has witnessed increasing engagement with emerging global powers, among which China stands out as one of the most influential. Traditionally, Africa's external relations were dominated by Western countries such as Britain, France, and the United States, largely due to colonial history and post-colonial economic ties. These relationships shaped Africa's political systems, economic structures, and foreign policies for many years. However, the late 20th and early 21st centuries marked a turning point as China emerged as a major global economic and political actor, redefining Africa's international partnerships.

China's relationship with Africa is not entirely new. Its roots can be traced back to the 1950s and 1960s when China supported African liberation movements and newly independent states. During this period, China positioned itself as a partner of developing nations, advocating for anti-imperialism, sovereignty, and mutual cooperation. Unlike Western countries, China emphasized non-interference in internal affairs and promoted solidarity among developing countries. This ideological foundation laid the groundwork for long-term cooperation between China and Africa.

The transformation of China into a global economic power following its economic reforms in 1978 significantly reshaped its foreign policy. As China's economy expanded rapidly, its demand for natural resources, energy, and new markets increased. Africa, with its vast natural resources, growing population, and development needs, became a strategic partner for China. Consequently, China intensified its economic engagement with African countries through trade, investment, and development financing.

Chinese investment in Africa has grown substantially across various sectors, including infrastructure, mining, oil and gas, agriculture, manufacturing, and telecommunications. Infrastructure development has been a major focus, as China has financed and constructed roads,

railways, ports, airports, power plants, and housing projects across the continent. These projects are often seen as addressing Africa's long-standing infrastructure deficit, which has hindered economic growth and regional integration. Chinese companies, both state-owned and private, play a dominant role in executing these projects, often funded through concessional loans and development assistance.

Trade between China and Africa has also expanded dramatically. China has become one of Africa's largest trading partners, importing raw materials such as oil, minerals, and agricultural products, while exporting manufactured goods, machinery, and consumer products. This trade relationship has contributed to economic growth in some African countries but has also raised concerns about trade imbalances, overdependence on raw material exports, and the impact of cheap Chinese goods on local industries.

Beyond economic engagement, China has strengthened its diplomatic relations with Africa through institutional frameworks such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC), established in 2000. FOCAC provides a platform for dialogue, policy coordination, and cooperation in areas such as trade, security, education, health, and cultural exchange. Through this forum, China has pledged financial assistance, debt relief, scholarships, and technical cooperation, further deepening diplomatic ties with African states.

China's diplomatic approach in Africa is characterized by the principle of non-interference and respect for national sovereignty. This approach has been appealing to many African governments, particularly those critical of Western conditionality's related to governance, human rights, and economic reforms. In return, African countries have often supported China's positions in international organizations such as the United Nations, including adherence to the "One China" policy. This mutual diplomatic support has strengthened China's influence on the global stage.

In addition to economic and diplomatic engagement, China has expanded its strategic influence in Africa. This includes military cooperation, arms sales, peacekeeping operations, and security partnerships. China has become one of the largest contributors of troops to United Nations peacekeeping missions in Africa, enhancing its image as a responsible global actor. The establishment of China's first overseas military base in Djibouti further highlights the strategic importance of Africa in China's foreign policy.

Despite the perceived benefits of China's engagement in Africa, the relationship has attracted criticism and controversy. Concerns have been raised about debt sustainability, particularly as some African countries struggle to repay Chinese loans. Critics argue that excessive borrowing may lead to financial dependency and loss of strategic assets. There are also concerns regarding labor practices, environmental standards, and the limited participation of local firms in Chinese funded projects.

Furthermore, some scholars and analysts argue that China's growing strategic presence could influence Africa's political autonomy and foreign policy choices. The debate over whether China's role in Africa represents a mutually beneficial partnership or a new form of economic and political dependency continues to generate scholarly and policy discussions. These debates highlight the complexity of China–Africa relations and the need for a balanced and objective analysis.

Against this background, this study seeks to examine China's roles in Africa with particular emphasis on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. Understanding the historical evolution and contemporary dynamics of China's engagement in Africa is essential for assessing its implications for Africa's development, sovereignty, and future international relations.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

China's growing presence in Africa has become one of the most significant developments in contemporary international relations. Over the years, Chinese investment, diplomatic engagement, and strategic activities have expanded rapidly across the African continent. While many African countries view China as a vital development partner that provides much-needed infrastructure, financial assistance, and political support, others have raised serious concerns about the long-term implications of this relationship. These mixed perceptions have created uncertainty regarding the true nature and impact of China's roles in Africa.

One major problem associated with China's involvement in Africa is the issue of economic dependency. Although Chinese investments have contributed to infrastructure development and economic growth in several African countries, there are concerns that these investments are heavily concentrated in extractive industries such as mining and oil. This pattern may reinforce

Africa's historical dependence on raw material exports rather than promote industrialization and economic diversification. In addition, trade relations between China and Africa are often characterized by imbalances, with Africa exporting primary commodities while importing finished goods, which may undermine local industries and long-term economic sustainability.

Another key problem is the growing level of debt incurred by African countries through Chinese loans. Many Chinese-funded infrastructure projects are financed through loans rather than grants, raising questions about debt sustainability and repayment capacity. Some African countries face increasing debt burdens, which could limit their fiscal space and economic independence. Critics argue that this situation may expose African countries to financial vulnerability and reduce their ability to make independent policy decisions.

Furthermore, concerns have been raised regarding labor practices, environmental standards, and transparency in Chinese-funded projects. Reports of limited employment opportunities for local workers, poor working conditions, and inadequate technology transfer have generated criticism from civil society groups and labor unions. Environmental degradation resulting from mining, construction, and industrial activities has also raised questions about the sustainability of Chinese investment in Africa.

From a diplomatic and strategic perspective, China's expanding influence in Africa has also generated debate. While China emphasizes non-interference in the internal affairs of African states, some observers argue that its diplomatic support and strategic engagement may indirectly influence domestic and foreign policy decisions. Africa's consistent support for China's positions in international organizations has led to concerns about political alignment and loss of diplomatic autonomy.

Despite the increasing importance of China–Africa relations, there remains a lack of comprehensive and balanced analysis that clearly examines the economic, diplomatic, and strategic dimensions of China's roles in Africa. Existing debates are often polarized, portraying China either as a benevolent development partner or as a self-interested power pursuing its own agenda. This lack of clarity creates a knowledge gap that makes it difficult for policymakers, scholars, and the public to fully understand the implications of China's engagement in Africa.

Therefore, the central problem of this study is to critically examine China's roles in Africa in terms of investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, with the aim of determining whether these engagements promote sustainable development and mutual benefit or contribute to new forms of dependency and influence. Addressing this problem is essential for guiding informed policy decisions and shaping Africa's future relations with China.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

The objectives of a study serve as a guide that directs the focus, scope, and overall purpose of the research. They explain clearly why the researcher embarked on the study and what the research intends to achieve. In examining China's roles in Africa with particular emphasis on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, it is important to outline objectives that are directly linked to the topic and capable of addressing the problems identified in the previous section. These objectives provide a framework for data collection, analysis, and interpretation, ensuring that the study remains focused and relevant.

This study is designed to achieve both a general objective and several specific objectives. The general objective presents the broad aim of the research, while the specific objectives break down this broad aim into manageable and measurable components. The specific objectives are formulated using key action verbs such as examine, assess, find out, evaluate, and determine, in line with standard academic practice and the guidelines provided for this study.

General Objective of the Study

The general objective of this study is to critically examine China's roles in Africa with particular focus on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, in order to understand the nature, extent, and implications of China's engagement on the economic, political, and strategic development of African countries.

This general objective reflects the core elements of the study's topic and highlights the intention to conduct a comprehensive analysis rather than a one-sided or superficial assessment. By focusing on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, the study seeks to capture the multidimensional

nature of China–Africa relations and provide a balanced understanding of both the benefits and challenges associated with China’s involvement in Africa.

Specific Objectives of the Study

To achieve the general objective stated above, the study is guided by the following specific objectives:

1. To examine the nature and pattern of Chinese investment in Africa

One of the primary objectives of this study is to examine the nature and pattern of Chinese investment across African countries. This involves analyzing the sectors that attract the most Chinese investment, such as infrastructure, mining, energy, manufacturing, agriculture, and telecommunications. By examining these investment patterns, the study seeks to understand whether Chinese investment is evenly distributed across sectors or concentrated in specific areas that align with China’s economic interests.

This objective also seeks to explore the forms of investment adopted by China in Africa, including foreign direct investment, concessional loans, grants, and public-private partnerships. Understanding these investment mechanisms is essential for assessing their sustainability and long-term impact on African economies. Furthermore, the study aims to examine the role of Chinese state-owned enterprises and private firms in executing investment projects and how their activities influence local economies.

By examining the nature and pattern of Chinese investment, this objective provides insight into whether China’s economic engagement promotes inclusive development or reinforces existing structural weaknesses in African economies.

2. To assess the impact of Chinese investment on Africa’s economic development

Another key objective of the study is to assess the impact of Chinese investment on economic development in Africa. Economic development in this context includes improvements in infrastructure, job creation, industrial growth, technology transfer, and overall economic productivity. This objective seeks to evaluate whether Chinese-funded projects contribute meaningfully to Africa's development goals or merely serve short-term economic needs.

This assessment involves analyzing both the positive and negative outcomes of Chinese investment. On the positive side, the study examines how infrastructure projects such as roads, railways, ports, and power plants have improved connectivity, reduced transportation costs, and stimulated economic activities. On the negative side, the study considers concerns related to debt accumulation, limited local content, environmental degradation, and the impact of Chinese imports on local industries.

By assessing the impact of Chinese investment on economic development, this objective aims to provide a balanced evaluation that moves beyond generalized assumptions and offers evidence based conclusions about the role of Chinese investment in Africa.

3. To find out the diplomatic strategies employed by China in its engagement with African countries

Diplomacy plays a central role in shaping China's relationship with Africa, and this study seeks to find out the diplomatic strategies used by China to strengthen its ties with African states. This objective focuses on China's approach to foreign policy in Africa, including its emphasis on noninterference, mutual respect, and win-win cooperation.

The study examines China's use of diplomatic platforms such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) to coordinate policies, provide development assistance, and strengthen political ties. It also explores how China uses soft power tools such as scholarships, cultural exchanges, medical missions, and humanitarian assistance to build goodwill and enhance its image in Africa.

Additionally, this objective seeks to understand how China's diplomatic strategies influence Africa's participation in international organizations and global governance. By finding out the

diplomatic methods employed by China, the study provides insight into how diplomacy complements economic and strategic engagement in shaping China's overall influence in Africa.

4. To evaluate the extent of China's strategic influence in Africa

Another important objective of the study is to evaluate the extent of China's strategic influence in Africa. Strategic influence in this context refers to China's involvement in security cooperation, military engagement, peacekeeping operations, and its ability to shape political and security outcomes on the continent.

This objective seeks to evaluate China's participation in United Nations peacekeeping missions in Africa, its military training and arms sales to African countries, and the establishment of strategic facilities such as military bases. The study also considers how China's strategic interests, including access to maritime routes, natural resources, and political support, influence its actions in Africa.

By evaluating the extent of China's strategic influence, the study aims to determine whether China's security engagement enhances regional stability and peace or raises concerns about geopolitical competition and sovereignty. This evaluation is critical for understanding the broader implications of China's presence in Africa within the global power structure.

5. To determine the benefits and challenges of China's roles in Africa

The final specific objective of the study is to determine the benefits and challenges associated with China's roles in Africa. This objective brings together the economic, diplomatic, and strategic dimensions of the study to provide a comprehensive assessment of China-Africa relations.

On the benefit side, the study seeks to identify how China's engagement has contributed to infrastructure development, economic growth, diplomatic support, and capacity building in African countries. On the challenge side, the study examines issues such as debt sustainability, environmental impact, labor concerns, political influence, and unequal power relations.

By determining both the benefits and challenges, this objective ensures that the study presents a balanced and objective analysis. It also provides a foundation for policy recommendations that can help African countries maximize the benefits of their relationship with China while minimizing potential risks.

Summary of the Objectives

In summary, the objectives of this study are designed to provide a comprehensive understanding of China's roles in Africa. The general objective sets the overall direction of the research, while the specific objectives break down the study into clear and achievable goals. Together, these objectives ensure that the study systematically examines Chinese investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, and evaluates their implications for Africa's development and international relations.

By clearly defining these objectives, the study establishes a strong foundation for subsequent chapters, including the literature review, research methodology, data analysis, and discussion of findings. The objectives also serve as a benchmark against which the success and relevance of the study can be measured.

1.4 Research Questions

Research questions are central to any academic investigation, as they clearly state the specific issues the study seeks to address. They serve as a guide for data collection, analysis, and interpretation, ensuring that the research remains focused on its stated objectives. In this study, the research questions are derived directly from the specific objectives outlined in the previous section. This alignment ensures consistency between the purpose of the study and the issues investigated.

Unlike questionnaire items, research questions are broader and more analytical in nature. They are not designed to elicit direct responses from respondents but rather to guide the researcher in exploring, explaining, and interpreting phenomena related to the study. In the context of this research, the questions are formulated to examine China's roles in Africa in terms of investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. Each research question is intended to address a specific dimension of China–Africa relations and contribute to a comprehensive understanding of the subject.

The following research questions guide this study:

1. What is the nature and pattern of Chinese investment in Africa?

This research question seeks to explore the characteristics, distribution, and structure of Chinese investment across African countries. It aims to examine the sectors that receive the highest levels of Chinese investment, such as infrastructure, energy, mining, manufacturing, agriculture, and telecommunications. By addressing this question, the study investigates whether Chinese investment is diversified or concentrated in particular sectors that align with China's economic interests.

The question also seeks to understand the mechanisms through which Chinese investment is delivered, including foreign direct investment, concessional loans, grants, and joint ventures. Additionally, it explores the role of Chinese state-owned enterprises and private firms in shaping investment patterns. Answering this question provides a foundation for assessing the broader economic implications of China's investment in Africa.

2. How has Chinese investment impacted economic development in Africa?

This research question focuses on the outcomes and consequences of Chinese investment on Africa's economic development. It seeks to examine both the positive and negative impacts of Chinese-funded projects on economic growth, infrastructure development, employment generation, and industrialization.

On the positive side, the question explores how Chinese investment has contributed to improved infrastructure, increased trade, and enhanced productive capacity. On the negative side, it considers issues such as debt sustainability, limited local content, environmental degradation, and the impact of Chinese imports on local industries. By addressing this question, the study aims to provide a balanced assessment of the developmental impact of Chinese investment in Africa.

3. What diplomatic strategies does China employ in its engagement with African countries?

This research question is designed to examine the diplomatic approaches and tools used by China in its relations with African states. It focuses on China's foreign policy principles, such as noninterference, mutual respect, and win-win cooperation, and how these principles are applied in practice.

The question also explores the role of diplomatic platforms such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) in strengthening political ties and coordinating development initiatives. Additionally, it examines the use of soft power instruments, including scholarships, cultural exchanges, medical assistance, and development aid, as tools for enhancing China’s diplomatic influence in Africa. Answering this question helps to clarify how diplomacy supports China’s broader economic and strategic objectives on the continent.

4. To what extent does China exercise strategic influence in Africa?

This research question seeks to evaluate the scope and depth of China’s strategic influence in Africa. Strategic influence in this context includes China’s involvement in security cooperation, military engagement, peacekeeping operations, and its ability to shape political and security outcomes.

The question examines China’s participation in United Nations peacekeeping missions in Africa, its military training programs, arms sales, and the establishment of strategic facilities. It also considers how China’s strategic interests, such as access to natural resources, trade routes, and political support, influence its engagement with African countries. Addressing this question provides insight into the geopolitical dimensions of China–Africa relations.

5. What are the benefits and challenges associated with China’s roles in Africa?

This research question aims to identify and analyze the advantages and disadvantages of China’s involvement in Africa. It seeks to determine how African countries have benefited from Chinese investment, diplomatic support, and strategic cooperation, as well as the challenges that have emerged from this relationship.

The question explores benefits such as infrastructure development, economic growth, and increased global visibility, alongside challenges such as debt accumulation, environmental concerns, labor issues, and political influence. By addressing this question, the study seeks to present a balanced perspective that recognizes both the opportunities and risks associated with China’s roles in Africa.

Summary of the Research Questions

The research questions outlined above are designed to guide the study in a systematic and comprehensive manner. Each question corresponds directly to a specific objective of the study, ensuring coherence and focus throughout the research process. Collectively, these questions enable the researcher to examine China's roles in Africa from economic, diplomatic, and strategic perspectives, and to draw informed conclusions based on evidence and analysis.

By answering these research questions, the study aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of China–Africa relations and provide insights that are relevant to policymakers, scholars, and other stakeholders interested in Africa's development and international partnerships.

1.5 Research Hypotheses

Hypotheses are tentative statements or scientific predictions formulated by a researcher to explain the possible relationship between two or more variables under investigation. They serve as a guide to the research process by providing a basis for data collection, analysis, and testing. In academic research, hypotheses help to transform abstract ideas into measurable and testable propositions, thereby enhancing the objectivity and reliability of the study.

In this research on China's roles in Africa with emphasis on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, hypotheses are formulated to reflect the key variables contained in the topic. These variables include Chinese investment, diplomacy, strategic influence, and their effects on Africa's economic development, political decisions, and international relations. The hypotheses are derived directly from the research objectives and research questions, ensuring consistency and logical flow throughout the study.

The study adopts both null hypotheses (H_0) and alternative hypotheses (H_1). The null hypothesis assumes that there is no significant relationship between the variables under consideration, while the alternative hypothesis assumes that a significant relationship exists. Testing these hypotheses enables the researcher to either accept or reject them based on empirical evidence gathered during the course of the study.

Purpose of Hypotheses in This Study

The formulation of hypotheses in this study serves several important purposes. First, it provides a clear direction for the research by narrowing the focus to specific relationships between variables.

Second, it enables the researcher to objectively assess the effects of China's engagement in Africa rather than relying on assumptions or opinions. Third, hypotheses help to ensure that the findings of the study are systematic, verifiable, and relevant to existing knowledge in international relations and development studies.

Given the ongoing debates surrounding China–Africa relations, hypotheses are particularly useful in distinguishing between perceived and actual impacts of China's involvement in Africa. They help to address questions such as whether Chinese investment truly contributes to economic development, whether diplomatic engagement influences political decisions, and whether China's strategic presence affects Africa's position in global affairs.

Hypothesis One: Chinese Investment and Economic Development in Africa

H₀₁ (Null Hypothesis): Chinese investment has no significant impact on economic development in Africa.

H₁₁ (Alternative Hypothesis): Chinese investment has a significant impact on economic development in Africa.

This hypothesis seeks to examine the relationship between Chinese investment and economic development in Africa. Economic development in this context includes infrastructure growth, employment creation, industrial expansion, and overall improvement in productive capacity. Chinese investment has been widely associated with large-scale infrastructure projects across Africa, such as roads, railways, ports, and power plants. However, there is ongoing debate about whether these investments translate into sustainable development outcomes.

By testing this hypothesis, the study aims to determine whether Chinese investment contributes positively to Africa's economic development or whether its impact is insignificant or uneven. This hypothesis is important because it addresses a core concern of policymakers and scholars regarding the effectiveness of Chinese investment as a development tool.

Hypothesis Two: Chinese Diplomacy and African Political Decisions

H₀₂ (Null Hypothesis): China's diplomatic engagement does not significantly influence political decisions in African countries.

H₁₂ (Alternative Hypothesis): China's diplomatic engagement significantly influences political decisions in African countries.

This hypothesis focuses on the relationship between Chinese diplomacy and political decision making in Africa. China's diplomatic approach emphasizes non-interference, mutual respect, and cooperation without political conditionalities. This approach has been attractive to many African governments, especially those dissatisfied with Western diplomatic practices.

Testing this hypothesis helps to determine whether China's diplomatic engagement merely facilitates cooperation or whether it exerts significant influence on Africa's domestic and foreign policy choices. It also addresses concerns that Africa's support for China's positions in international organizations may reflect diplomatic influence rather than independent decision making.

Hypothesis Three: Strategic Influence and Africa's International Relations

H₀₃ (Null Hypothesis): China's strategic presence has no significant influence on Africa's international relations.

H₁₃ (Alternative Hypothesis): China's strategic presence has a significant influence on Africa's international relations.

This hypothesis examines the relationship between China's strategic engagement and Africa's international relations. China's strategic presence in Africa includes military cooperation, peacekeeping operations, arms sales, and security partnerships. These activities have expanded

China's influence in Africa's security landscape and raised questions about geopolitical competition.

By testing this hypothesis, the study seeks to determine whether China's strategic involvement alters Africa's relationships with other global powers or reshapes its role in international politics. This hypothesis is crucial for understanding the broader geopolitical implications of China–Africa relations.

Hypothesis Four: Chinese Engagement and Debt Sustainability in Africa

H₀₄ (Null Hypothesis): Chinese financial assistance does not significantly affect debt sustainability in African countries.

H₁₄ (Alternative Hypothesis): Chinese financial assistance significantly affects debt sustainability in African countries.

This hypothesis addresses one of the most controversial aspects of China–Africa relations: debt sustainability. Many Chinese-funded projects are financed through loans, raising concerns about the ability of African countries to repay them. Critics argue that excessive borrowing could lead to financial dependency and loss of economic sovereignty.

Testing this hypothesis allows the study to assess whether Chinese loans contribute significantly to Africa's debt challenges or whether their impact is overstated. This analysis is important for guiding responsible borrowing and financial management policies in African countries.

Hypothesis Five: Chinese Engagement and Development Outcomes in Africa

H₀₅ (Null Hypothesis): China's overall engagement does not significantly contribute to development outcomes in Africa.

H₁₅ (Alternative Hypothesis): China's overall engagement significantly contributes to development outcomes in Africa.

This hypothesis takes a holistic approach by examining the combined effects of Chinese investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence on development outcomes in Africa. Development outcomes include economic growth, infrastructure development, institutional capacity building, and social development.

By testing this hypothesis, the study seeks to determine whether China's roles in Africa collectively promote sustainable development or whether their impact is limited. This hypothesis integrates the economic, political, and strategic dimensions of the study, providing a comprehensive assessment of China's engagement in Africa.

Relevance of the Hypotheses to the Study

The hypotheses formulated in this section are directly linked to the objectives and research questions of the study. They provide a structured framework for analyzing data and drawing conclusions based on evidence rather than speculation. Each hypothesis addresses a specific dimension of China's roles in Africa, ensuring that the study remains focused and coherent.

Furthermore, the hypotheses contribute to existing academic debates by offering testable propositions that can be supported or refuted through empirical analysis. This enhances the academic value of the study and provides a solid foundation for policy recommendations.

Summary of the Hypotheses

In summary, the hypotheses in this study serve as scientific tools for examining the relationships between Chinese investment, diplomacy, strategic influence, and Africa's development and international relations. By testing these hypotheses, the study aims to provide objective and evidence-based insights into China's roles in Africa. The results of the hypothesis testing will inform the conclusions and recommendations presented in later chapters of the research.

1.6 Scope of the Study

The scope of a study defines the boundaries within which the research is conducted. It clearly outlines what the study covers and what it does not cover, thereby preventing ambiguity and misinterpretation of the research findings. By defining the scope, the researcher is able to focus on specific areas relevant to the research problem and objectives, while also acknowledging the limitations of the study. In this research, the scope is carefully defined in terms of content, geographical coverage, time frame, variables of interest, and sources of data.

This study focuses on China's roles in Africa, with particular emphasis on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. These three areas form the core variables of the research and represent the key dimensions through which China engages with African countries. Other aspects of China–Africa relations that fall outside these variables are not examined in detail, except where they are necessary to provide context or support the analysis.

In terms of content scope, the study examines Chinese investment in Africa by analyzing its nature, pattern, and impact on economic development. This includes investments in infrastructure, energy, mining, manufacturing, agriculture, and telecommunications. The study also examines China's diplomatic engagement with African countries, focusing on diplomatic strategies, policy frameworks, and institutional platforms such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation

(FOCAC). In addition, the study explores China's strategic influence in Africa, including security cooperation, military engagement, peacekeeping operations, and geopolitical considerations.

The geographical scope of the study covers Africa as a continent, with reference to selected African countries where China's presence is particularly significant. Due to the vast size and diversity of Africa, it is not feasible to examine all African countries in equal detail. Therefore, the study relies on selected case examples and regional trends to illustrate China's roles in Africa. These examples are used to provide a representative understanding of China–Africa relations rather than an exhaustive country-by-country analysis.

With regard to the time scope, the study focuses primarily on the period from the early 2000s to the present. This period is significant because it marks the institutionalization and rapid expansion of China–Africa relations following the establishment of FOCAC in 2000. While historical references are made to earlier periods to provide background and context, the analysis concentrates on contemporary developments that reflect the current dynamics of China's engagement in Africa.

The variable scope of the study includes independent and dependent variables. The independent variables are Chinese investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, while the dependent variables include economic development, political decision-making, and Africa's international relations. By clearly defining these variables, the study ensures that the analysis remains focused on the relationships and impacts relevant to the research objectives.

In terms of methodological scope, the study relies primarily on secondary data sources. These include academic journals, textbooks, government publications, policy reports, international organization documents, and credible online sources. The use of secondary data is appropriate for a study of this nature, as it allows for comprehensive analysis of existing knowledge and trends in China–Africa relations. Primary data collection methods such as surveys or interviews are outside the scope of this study.

The study is also limited by certain practical constraints, including time, availability of data, and access to resources. As an undergraduate research project, the study is designed to meet academic requirements within a defined timeframe and resource availability. These limitations are acknowledged to ensure transparency and to guide interpretation of the findings.

In summary, the scope of this study is limited to an examination of China’s roles in Africa in terms of investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, within a defined geographical, temporal, and methodological framework. By clearly stating the scope, the study establishes realistic boundaries and ensures that its findings are focused, relevant, and academically sound.

1.7 Significance of the Study

The significance of a study explains the importance and value of the research to individuals, institutions, policymakers, and the broader society. It highlights how the findings of the study contribute to existing knowledge, influence decision-making, and address practical or theoretical issues. In the context of this research on China’s roles in Africa with emphasis on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, the significance of the study lies in its ability to provide a balanced, informed, and evidence-based understanding of one of the most important international relationships shaping Africa’s contemporary development and global positioning.

China–Africa relations have attracted widespread attention from scholars, policymakers, international organizations, and the general public. However, opinions on China’s involvement in Africa remain deeply divided. While some view China as a genuine development partner offering alternatives to Western dominance, others perceive its presence as a new form of economic and political influence that may undermine Africa’s long-term interests. This study is therefore significant because it seeks to move beyond polarized debates by providing a systematic and objective analysis of China’s roles in Africa.

Significance to Policymakers and Government Institutions in Africa

One of the major contributions of this study is its relevance to policymakers and government institutions in African countries. As African governments continue to engage with China through trade agreements, investment deals, and diplomatic partnerships, there is a growing need for informed decision-making based on a clear understanding of the implications of such engagements. This study provides policymakers with insights into the nature and impact of Chinese investment, enabling them to negotiate better terms, design effective policies, and ensure that development projects align with national priorities.

The study also highlights the diplomatic and strategic dimensions of China–Africa relations, helping policymakers assess how China’s engagement influences political autonomy and foreign policy choices. By identifying both the benefits and challenges of China’s involvement, the study supports the formulation of balanced policies that maximize gains while minimizing risks such as excessive debt, overdependence, and loss of strategic assets.

Significance to Scholars and Academic Researchers

From an academic perspective, this study contributes to the growing body of literature on international relations, development studies, and political economy. By examining China’s roles in Africa through the interconnected lenses of investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, the study provides a holistic framework for understanding China–Africa relations. This integrated approach addresses gaps in existing literature, which often focuses on a single dimension of the relationship.

The study also provides a foundation for future research by identifying key trends, debates, and research gaps. Scholars and researchers can build on the findings of this study to conduct more detailed analyses, comparative studies, or empirical research on specific aspects of China–Africa relations. In this way, the study contributes to the advancement of knowledge and scholarly discourse.

Significance to Students and Educational Institutions

This study is also significant to students and educational institutions, particularly those studying international relations, political science, economics, and African studies. It serves as a valuable academic resource that enhances understanding of global power dynamics and Africa’s place in the international system. By presenting complex issues in a clear and structured manner, the study supports learning and critical thinking among students.

For undergraduate students, the study provides a model for conducting systematic research and applying theoretical concepts to real-world issues. It demonstrates how academic research can be used to analyze contemporary global challenges and inform practical solutions.

Significance to International Organizations and Development Partners

International organizations and development partners operating in Africa can also benefit from the findings of this study. By examining the impact of Chinese investment and diplomacy on development outcomes, the study provides insights that can inform coordination, cooperation, and policy alignment among different development actors. Understanding China’s approach to development assistance and strategic engagement can help international organizations design complementary strategies that support sustainable development in Africa.

The study also contributes to discussions on global governance and South–South cooperation by highlighting alternative development models and partnership frameworks. This is particularly relevant in an era of shifting global power dynamics and increasing competition among major powers.

Significance to the African Private Sector and Civil Society

The African private sector and civil society organizations are important stakeholders in China–Africa relations. Chinese investment has significant implications for local businesses, labor markets, and communities. This study provides insights into how Chinese projects affect employment, technology transfer, and local industry participation, enabling private sector actors to identify opportunities and challenges.

Civil society organizations can also use the findings of this study to advocate for transparency, accountability, and sustainable development practices. By highlighting issues such as labor standards, environmental impact, and community engagement, the study supports efforts to ensure that development projects benefit local populations and respect social and environmental norms.

Significance to the General Public

For the general public, this study enhances awareness and understanding of China’s roles in Africa. Public discourse on China–Africa relations is often shaped by media narratives and political rhetoric, which may oversimplify or misrepresent complex realities. This study provides a balanced and evidence-based perspective that helps the public make informed judgments about China’s involvement in Africa.

An informed public is better equipped to engage in meaningful discussions about national development strategies, foreign policy choices, and international partnerships. By contributing to public understanding, the study supports democratic participation and accountability.

Contribution to Policy Formulation and Implementation

Another important significance of this study lies in its potential contribution to policy formulation and implementation. The findings can inform the design of policies that promote sustainable investment, responsible borrowing, and effective diplomatic engagement. By identifying best practices and potential pitfalls in China–Africa relations, the study provides practical recommendations that can guide policymakers and development practitioners.

The study also underscores the importance of strengthening institutional capacity, regulatory frameworks, and negotiation skills in African countries. These insights are critical for ensuring that Africa's engagement with China contributes to long-term development goals rather than short term gains.

Summary of the Significance of the Study

In summary, the significance of this study lies in its ability to provide a comprehensive and balanced analysis of China's roles in Africa. The study is valuable to policymakers, scholars, students, international organizations, the private sector, civil society, and the general public. By examining investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, the study contributes to a deeper understanding of China–Africa relations and supports informed decision-making, academic research, and public discourse.

Ultimately, the study aims to contribute to the development of policies and strategies that promote mutually beneficial partnerships between China and Africa, while safeguarding Africa's economic sovereignty, political autonomy, and long-term development interests.

1.8 Operational Definition of Terms

Operational definitions clarify the meaning of key terms and concepts in a study, specifically in the context in which they are used. Unlike dictionary definitions, operational definitions are tailored to the variables and objectives of the research, ensuring that the terms are measurable, understandable, and consistent throughout the study. In this research, which focuses on China's roles in Africa: Investment, Diplomacy, and Strategic Influence, several key terms are operationally defined to eliminate ambiguity and enhance clarity.

1. China

In this study, China refers specifically to the People's Republic of China (PRC) as a sovereign state, including its government institutions, state-owned enterprises, private corporations, diplomatic missions, and strategic agencies involved in international engagement with African

countries. It excludes unofficial or independent Chinese entities that have no direct link to China's foreign policy objectives.

2. Africa

For the purposes of this research, Africa refers to the continent comprising 54 recognized sovereign countries, with a focus on those nations that have significant engagement with China in terms of trade, investment, diplomatic relations, and strategic partnerships. While the study acknowledges the diversity of Africa, it treats the continent as a collective region for analyzing broad patterns of China–Africa relations, with references to specific countries as illustrative examples.

3. Investment

Investment in this study is defined as the allocation of Chinese financial, material, or technological resources into African countries with the intention of generating economic, infrastructural, or strategic returns. This includes:

Foreign Direct Investment (FDI): Chinese companies establishing or acquiring businesses in Africa.

Infrastructure Projects: Funding and construction of roads, railways, ports, airports, energy facilities, and industrial zones.

Concessional Loans and Grants: Loans provided by Chinese financial institutions for development projects, often at lower-than-market interest rates.

Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs): Collaborative ventures between Chinese entities and African governments to implement development projects.

In the study, investment is measured by the type, scale, and sectoral distribution of Chinese financial involvement and its impact on economic outcomes such as employment creation, GDP growth, and industrial development.

4. Diplomacy

Diplomacy refers operationally to the strategic engagement of China with African governments and institutions to promote political cooperation, mutual understanding, and international partnership. It encompasses formal and informal channels of interaction, including:

Bilateral Diplomacy: Official state-to-state relationships, including visits, treaties, and agreements.

Multilateral Diplomacy: Engagement through international forums such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC), the United Nations, and regional African organizations.

Soft Power Tools: Scholarships, cultural exchanges, medical missions, development assistance, and media outreach aimed at fostering goodwill.

In this study, diplomacy is evaluated by examining the methods, scope, and effectiveness of China’s political engagement and its influence on African political decision-making and international alignment.

5. Strategic Influence

Strategic influence in this research refers to China’s ability to shape political, security, and economic outcomes in African countries and the broader region in alignment with its global interests. This includes both military and non-military dimensions:

Military Cooperation: Joint training exercises, arms sales, defense agreements, and military advisory services.

Peacekeeping and Security Contributions: China’s participation in United Nations peacekeeping missions, conflict mediation, and support for regional stability.

Geopolitical Presence: Establishment of overseas facilities, ports, or logistical hubs to protect Chinese interests and enhance its influence in strategic regions.

Strategic influence is measured by assessing the scope of China’s security engagement, participation in peacekeeping, and the capacity to affect African countries’ foreign and domestic policy decisions.

6. Economic Development

In this study, economic development refers to the improvement of the economic well-being and living standards of African countries as a result of Chinese engagement, including:

Increased GDP and industrial output.

Job creation and skills transfer.

Improved infrastructure and connectivity.

Enhanced access to technology and capital.

Economic development is operationalized by evaluating measurable indicators such as employment rates, infrastructure projects completed, trade volume, and investment inflows linked to Chinese activities.

7. Debt Sustainability

Debt sustainability is defined as the ability of an African country to meet its debt obligations to Chinese lenders without compromising fiscal stability, economic growth, or social development.

It is measured by:

- Debt-to-GDP ratios.
- Loan repayment terms.
- Fiscal space for development spending.

Debt sustainability is particularly important in assessing whether Chinese loans contribute to long term development or increase financial vulnerability.

8. Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC)

FOCAC is operationally defined as the primary multilateral platform through which China and African countries coordinate policies, negotiate agreements, and implement cooperation projects across economic, political, and social domains. Its significance lies in fostering structured

engagement, institutionalizing partnerships, and providing formal mechanisms for development assistance.

9. Non-Interference Policy

In the context of this study, China's non-interference policy refers to its stated principle of refraining from dictating or intervening in the internal political affairs of African countries, including governance, human rights, or domestic politics. This principle is central to China's diplomatic strategy and is measured by analyzing policy statements, agreements, and observed behavior in bilateral and multilateral engagements.

10. Development Outcomes

Development outcomes refer to the tangible and measurable results of China's engagement in Africa across economic, political, and social dimensions. This includes:

- Infrastructure quality and coverage.
- Economic growth indicators.
- Political stability and international alignment.
- Capacity building and technological transfer.

These outcomes are operationalized through analysis of project reports, economic data, and policy assessments to determine the effectiveness of Chinese engagement.

Summary

Operationally defining these key terms ensures clarity and consistency throughout the study. Each term is directly linked to the research objectives, questions, and hypotheses, enabling systematic measurement and analysis. By providing precise definitions, this study avoids ambiguity and ensures that readers, policymakers, and other stakeholders clearly understand the variables under investigation. These definitions also provide a foundation for subsequent chapters, including

literature review, methodology, data analysis, and discussion of findings, ensuring that the research remains focused, coherent, and academically rigorous.

CHAPTER TWO

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

The purpose of this chapter is to critically review existing literature related to China's roles in Africa, with particular focus on economic investment, diplomatic engagement, and strategic influence. A literature review is a vital component of any academic research because it provides a theoretical and empirical foundation upon which the study is built. It enables the researcher to understand what has already been studied, how it has been studied, and what gaps still exist within the body of knowledge. In this chapter, relevant scholarly works, policy documents, and empirical studies are examined and synthesized in order to situate the present study within existing academic discourse.

Literature review refers to the systematic examination, analysis, and interpretation of previous studies that are relevant to the variables under investigation. It does not involve a mere reproduction or repetition of scholars' ideas, but rather a critical engagement with those ideas in order to identify patterns, trends, contradictions, and gaps. In the context of this study, the literature reviewed covers China–Africa relations from both global and African perspectives, with emphasis on how China's involvement has shaped economic development, political relations, and strategic outcomes across the African continent.

Over the past two decades, China's presence in Africa has expanded rapidly, attracting significant attention from scholars, policymakers, and international organizations. This growing interest is largely due to China's transformation into a major global economic power and its increasing engagement with developing regions, particularly Africa. As a result, a vast body of literature has emerged, offering diverse interpretations of China's motives, methods, and impacts in Africa. Some scholars portray China as a development partner offering much-needed infrastructure and

financial support, while others view China as a neo-colonial actor driven by resource extraction and geopolitical ambitions.

This chapter intends to review these competing perspectives in a balanced and analytical manner. By examining both positive and critical viewpoints, the study seeks to provide a comprehensive understanding of China's roles in Africa. The literature review is structured to move from broad conceptual discussions to more specific thematic areas, allowing for logical flow and clarity.

Specifically, this chapter is organized around the following key sub-headings:

1. Conceptual review of China–Africa relations
2. China's investment in Africa
3. China's diplomatic engagement in Africa
4. China's strategic and geopolitical influence in Africa
5. General (global) perspectives on China's role in Africa
6. African (local) perspectives on China's role in Africa

Each of these sub-sections examines existing literature relevant to the topic, highlighting major arguments, findings, and areas of debate. The conceptual review provides definitions and explanations of key concepts such as China–Africa relations, foreign direct investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. This helps to clarify how these concepts are understood and applied by different scholars.

The review of China's investment in Africa focuses on the nature, scope, and impact of Chinese economic activities on the continent. It examines areas such as infrastructure development, natural resource extraction, industrialization, and employment creation. Scholarly debates surrounding debt sustainability, technology transfer, and local participation are also discussed. This section is important because economic engagement is often regarded as the most visible and influential aspect of China's presence in Africa.

The section on China's diplomatic engagement explores how China interacts with African states at the political and institutional levels. This includes an examination of China's foreign policy principles, bilateral and multilateral relations, and mechanisms such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC). Attention is given to how China's diplomatic style differs from that of Western countries and how African states perceive and respond to this approach.

China's strategic influence in Africa is another critical area reviewed in this chapter. Strategic influence goes beyond economics and diplomacy to include security cooperation, peacekeeping, military engagement, and geopolitical positioning. Literature in this area assesses whether China's growing strategic presence contributes to stability and development or introduces new forms of dependency and competition.

In order to ensure balance, this chapter reviews literature from both general (global) and African (local) perspectives. Global perspectives, particularly from Western scholars, often frame China's role in Africa within broader debates about globalization, power transition, and international competition. African perspectives, on the other hand, tend to emphasize practical development outcomes, agency, and the need for strategic engagement. By comparing these viewpoints, the chapter provides a more nuanced understanding of China–Africa relations.

Furthermore, this chapter identifies gaps in existing literature that justify the need for the present study. Although numerous studies have examined China's engagement in Africa, many focus on isolated aspects such as trade, investment, or diplomacy. There is limited integrated analysis that simultaneously examines economic, diplomatic, and strategic dimensions within a single framework, particularly from an African-centered perspective. This gap underscores the relevance of the current research.

In summary, this chapter serves as a foundation for the study by reviewing, analyzing, and synthesizing relevant literature on China's roles in Africa. It establishes the intellectual context of the research, clarifies key concepts, and highlights areas where further investigation is required. The insights gained from this review inform the research questions, methodology, and analysis presented in subsequent chapters.

2.2 Summary of Findings from Reviewed Literature and Identified Research Gap

A critical review of existing literature on China's roles in Africa reveals a wide range of findings, perspectives, and interpretations. Scholars from different ideological, geographical, and disciplinary backgrounds have examined China–Africa relations, producing diverse conclusions about the nature, motivations, and consequences of China's engagement on the African continent. This section synthesizes the major findings from the reviewed literature under the three core dimensions of this study, investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, and subsequently identifies the gaps that necessitate further research.

Summary of Findings on China's Investment in Africa

One of the most extensively studied aspects of China's engagement in Africa is economic investment. A substantial body of literature agrees that China has become one of Africa's largest trading partners and sources of foreign direct investment. Studies consistently highlight that Chinese investments are heavily concentrated in infrastructure development, including roads, railways, ports, airports, power plants, and telecommunications. Scholars such as Brautigam argue that China's infrastructure-for-resources model has played a significant role in addressing Africa's long-standing infrastructure deficit, which Western donors and institutions had often neglected due to perceived risks and low returns.

Many researchers find that Chinese investment has contributed positively to economic growth in several African countries. Improved infrastructure has enhanced connectivity, reduced transportation costs, and facilitated trade within and across borders. Some studies also note that Chinese investments have supported industrialization through the establishment of manufacturing zones and special economic zones in countries such as Ethiopia, Nigeria, and Zambia. These developments are often cited as evidence that China's engagement goes beyond mere resource extraction.

However, the literature also reveals significant criticisms. A recurring concern is the issue of debt sustainability. Several scholars argue that Chinese loans, particularly those tied to large infrastructure projects, have increased Africa's debt burden. Although China often provides loans with fewer political conditions compared to Western lenders, critics contend that the lack of

transparency in loan agreements can expose African countries to financial vulnerability. The concept of “debt-trap diplomacy” has been widely debated, with some scholars asserting that China intentionally uses debt to gain strategic leverage, while others dismiss this claim as exaggerated and unsupported by empirical evidence.

Another major finding relates to employment and local content. While Chinese projects are credited with job creation, some studies indicate that Chinese firms often rely on imported labor and materials, limiting technology transfer and skill development for local populations.

Conversely, other scholars argue that the level of local employment varies by country and sector, suggesting that outcomes depend largely on host-country policies and regulatory frameworks rather than solely on Chinese practices

Summary of Findings on China’s Diplomatic Engagement in Africa

The literature on China’s diplomacy in Africa highlights China’s emphasis on principles such as non-interference, mutual respect for sovereignty, and win-win cooperation. Many scholars observe that this diplomatic approach has resonated strongly with African leaders, particularly those who view Western conditionality as intrusive or politically motivated. China’s policy of engaging with all governments, regardless of their political systems, has enabled it to establish diplomatic relations with nearly all African states.

A significant finding in the literature is the role of the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) as a central institutional platform for China–Africa relations. Scholars widely agree that FOCAC has enhanced coordination, dialogue, and policy alignment between China and African countries. Through FOCAC summits and action plans, China has been able to articulate long-term strategies and commitments in areas such as development finance, trade facilitation, capacity building, and cultural exchange.

The literature also suggests that China’s diplomatic engagement has increased Africa’s bargaining power on the global stage. By diversifying partnerships and reducing dependence on traditional Western allies, African states have gained greater leverage in international negotiations. Some studies argue that China’s presence has contributed to a more multipolar international system, offering African countries alternative development models and sources of support.

Despite these positive assessments, criticisms persist. Some scholars argue that China's noninterference policy may indirectly support authoritarian regimes by providing financial and diplomatic backing without demanding governance reforms. Others contend that China's diplomatic engagement prioritizes elite-to-elite relationships, often neglecting civil society and grassroots participation. These concerns raise questions about the long-term implications of China's diplomatic model for democratic governance and accountability in Africa.

Summary of Findings on China's Strategic Influence in Africa

China's strategic influence in Africa has emerged as an increasingly important area of scholarly inquiry. The literature indicates that China's strategic engagement includes military cooperation, arms sales, peacekeeping operations, anti-piracy missions, and the establishment of its first overseas military base in Djibouti. Scholars generally agree that China's strategic presence reflects its broader global ambitions and desire to protect its economic interests and citizens abroad.

Several studies highlight China's growing contribution to United Nations peacekeeping missions in Africa. China is often praised for being one of the largest contributors of peacekeepers among the permanent members of the UN Security Council. This involvement is seen by some scholars as evidence of China's commitment to regional stability and international responsibility.

At the same time, concerns are raised about the geopolitical implications of China's expanding strategic footprint. Some analysts interpret China's military presence as a challenge to Western influence, particularly that of the United States and former colonial powers. The establishment of military facilities and increased security cooperation are viewed by critics as indicators of strategic competition rather than purely defensive or humanitarian motives.

Nevertheless, African perspectives in the literature often emphasize pragmatism. Many African scholars argue that strategic cooperation with China provides opportunities for capacity building, security sector reform, and diversification of defense partnerships. They contend that Africa is not merely a passive recipient of Chinese influence but an active participant that negotiates and shapes the terms of engagement.

Identified Research Gap

Despite the extensive body of literature on China–Africa relations, several gaps remain evident.

First, much of the existing research examines China’s investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence as separate and isolated phenomena. There is limited integrated analysis that simultaneously considers how these three dimensions interact and reinforce one another within a single framework. This fragmented approach restricts comprehensive understanding of China’s overall role in Africa.

Second, many studies are dominated by global or Western perspectives, often framing China’s engagement in Africa in terms of competition, threat, or neo-colonialism. While these perspectives offer valuable insights, they sometimes underrepresent African voices and experiences. There is a need for research that places greater emphasis on African agency, perceptions, and strategic choices in engaging with China.

Third, existing literature tends to generalize Africa as a homogeneous entity, overlooking variations among countries and regions. Differences in political systems, economic structures, and governance capacities significantly influence the outcomes of China’s engagement. More nuanced analysis is required to capture these variations without losing sight of broader continental trends.

Finally, there is limited focus on the long-term implications of China’s roles in Africa. Many studies assess short- or medium-term outcomes, leaving questions about sustainability, institutional development, and future trajectories insufficiently explored. This study seeks to contribute to the literature by addressing these gaps through a holistic examination of China’s investment, diplomatic, and strategic roles in Africa.

In summary, while existing literature provides valuable insights into China–Africa relations, notable gaps remain in terms of integrated analysis, African-centered perspectives, and long-term assessment. The identification of these gaps justifies the relevance of the present study and underscores its contribution to existing knowledge.

CHAPTER THREE

METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter focuses on the methodology adopted for this study on China's roles in Africa, with particular emphasis on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. Methodology is a crucial part of any academic research because it explains how the study was conducted and why certain methods were chosen over others. It provides a clear roadmap that guides the entire research process, ensuring that the study is systematic, logical, and credible. Without a well-defined methodology, the findings of a research work may be questioned or considered unreliable.

The main purpose of this chapter is to describe the procedures and techniques used in collecting, organizing, and analyzing data relevant to the study. It explains the research design adopted, the population of the study, the sample size and sampling technique, as well as the reliability and validity of the research instruments used. In addition, the chapter outlines the data collection procedure and the methods employed in analyzing the collected data. Each of these components plays an important role in ensuring that the objectives of the study are achieved.

Given the nature of the topic; China's roles in Africa, this study relies heavily on existing information, scholarly debates, and documented evidence. Issues relating to international relations, foreign investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence are complex and broad, making it difficult to generate primary data within the scope of an undergraduate research project. Therefore, a carefully structured methodological approach is required to ensure that relevant and credible information is gathered and analyzed appropriately.

This chapter also justifies the choice of research methods adopted for the study. Every research method has its strengths and limitations, and it is important for the researcher to clearly explain why a particular method is suitable for the study. By doing so, the researcher demonstrates awareness of alternative approaches and provides reasons for selecting the most appropriate one.

This transparency enhances the academic integrity of the research. Furthermore, the chapter serves as a link between the theoretical discussions in Chapter Two and the analysis that will be presented in subsequent chapters. The literature review highlighted various scholarly perspectives on China–Africa relations and identified gaps that this study seeks to address. The methodology outlined in this chapter explains how the researcher intends to respond to those gaps through systematic investigation and analysis.

In summary, this chapter presents a detailed explanation of the methods and procedures used to conduct the study. It is organized into several sections, including research design, population of the study, sample size and sampling technique, reliability and validity of instruments, data collection procedure, and methods of data analysis. Together, these sections provide a clear and comprehensive understanding of how the research was carried out, thereby laying a solid foundation for the analysis and discussion of findings.

3.2 Research Design

Research design refers to the overall plan or structure that guides how a study is conducted, from data collection to analysis and interpretation. It is essentially the blueprint that shows how the research problem will be addressed and how the objectives of the study will be achieved. A well-chosen research design ensures that the study is systematic, logical, and capable of producing reliable findings. In this study, the research design was carefully selected to suit the nature of the topic and the objectives outlined in Chapter One.

This study adopted a descriptive research design. Descriptive research design is used when a study aims to describe, explain, and interpret existing phenomena as they occur, without manipulating variables or introducing experimental conditions. The focus of this research is to examine China’s roles in Africa in terms of investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence as they currently exist and as they have developed over time. Since the study does not seek to test a treatment or experiment with variables, the descriptive design is considered the most appropriate.

The choice of a descriptive design allows the researcher to provide a detailed and objective account of China–Africa relations. It enables the study to capture the nature, scope, and patterns of China’s

engagement in Africa using already available information. Through this design, the researcher is able to explain how China invests in African economies, how diplomatic relations are conducted, and how strategic influence is exercised across the continent. This approach supports a broad understanding of the subject rather than focusing on a narrow or controlled setting.

In addition to being descriptive, the study also adopts a qualitative research approach. Qualitative research emphasizes understanding meanings, interpretations, and perspectives rather than numerical measurement. Given that issues of foreign policy, diplomacy, and strategic influence are complex and context-dependent, qualitative analysis provides the flexibility needed to explore these issues in depth. It allows the researcher to examine arguments, opinions, and interpretations presented by different scholars and institutions.

The qualitative approach is particularly suitable for this study because much of the data required already exists in documented form. These include academic journal articles, books, policy papers, government reports, and publications from international organizations. Through qualitative analysis, the researcher is able to critically examine these materials, identify recurring themes, and interpret their relevance to the research objectives. This method also makes it possible to compare different viewpoints and highlight areas of agreement and disagreement among scholars.

Another important aspect of the research design is its historical dimension. Although the study focuses on contemporary China–Africa relations, it also considers the historical development of this relationship. Understanding how China’s involvement in Africa has evolved over time is essential for explaining its current roles and influence. The descriptive design allows the researcher to trace this historical progression and link past developments to present realities.

The research design further supports the integration of multiple dimensions of analysis. Instead of examining investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence in isolation, the design allows the researcher to explore how these elements are interconnected. For example, Chinese investment projects often strengthen diplomatic ties, while diplomatic engagement may create opportunities for strategic cooperation. By adopting a flexible and descriptive design, the study is able to capture these interrelationships in a coherent manner.

The selection of this research design was also influenced by practical considerations. As an undergraduate research project, the study operates within limitations of time, resources, and access to respondents. Conducting large-scale surveys or experiments across multiple African countries would be impractical. The descriptive qualitative design provides a realistic and effective alternative, enabling the researcher to produce a meaningful and academically sound study within these constraints.

Despite its strengths, the descriptive qualitative research design has certain limitations. One limitation is that it relies heavily on secondary data, which may reflect the biases or perspectives of the original authors. However, this limitation was addressed by consulting multiple sources and comparing information across different publications. This triangulation of sources helps to reduce bias and improve the credibility of the findings.

In summary, the descriptive qualitative research design adopted for this study is well-suited to the research topic and objectives. It allows for an in-depth examination of China's roles in Africa by drawing on existing literature and documented evidence. The design supports flexibility, critical analysis, and comprehensive coverage of the subject matter, thereby ensuring that the study provides a balanced and insightful understanding of China's investment, diplomatic, and strategic influence in Africa.

3.3 Population of the Study

The population of a study refers to the total group of individuals, materials, events, or objects that are relevant to the subject under investigation and from which data can be obtained. Clearly defining the population helps the researcher to specify the boundaries of the study and to ensure that the data collected are appropriate for achieving the research objectives. In this study, the population is defined in relation to the nature of the research topic and the methodological approach adopted.

Given that this research focuses on China's roles in Africa with emphasis on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, the population of the study does not consist of human respondents such as individuals or groups. Instead, the population comprises documented and

published materials that address issues related to China–Africa relations. These materials represent the body of knowledge and documented evidence upon which the study is based.

Specifically, the population of the study includes academic journal articles, textbooks, conference papers, government publications, policy documents, official reports, and publications from international organizations. It also includes reports from reputable research institutions, think tanks, and development agencies that have conducted studies on China’s engagement in Africa. Examples of such institutions include the World Bank, United Nations, African Union, China–Africa Research Initiative, and similar bodies. These sources provide reliable and relevant information on economic investment, diplomatic relations, and strategic cooperation between China and African countries.

The population further includes documented case studies of specific African countries or regions that illustrate China’s involvement in infrastructure development, trade, aid, security cooperation, and diplomatic engagement. These case studies offer practical insights into how China’s roles are manifested in different contexts across the African continent. By drawing from a wide range of documented cases, the study is able to present a more comprehensive and balanced analysis.

In terms of time frame, the population of the study covers materials published within a relevant historical and contemporary period. This includes literature that traces the early stages of China–Africa relations as well as more recent publications that examine current trends and developments.

The inclusion of both older and recent sources allows the researcher to understand how China’s roles in Africa have evolved over time and how historical factors influence present-day interactions.

The choice of this population is largely influenced by the scope and objectives of the study. Since the research seeks to examine broad patterns and roles rather than individual opinions, secondary data sources provide the most suitable population. These sources contain analyzed and interpreted information that would be difficult for an undergraduate researcher to generate independently through primary data collection.

Another important aspect of the population is its global nature. The materials reviewed originate from different geographical and ideological backgrounds, including African scholars, Chinese

scholars, and Western researchers. This diversity ensures that the study captures multiple perspectives on China's roles in Africa, reducing the risk of one-sided analysis. It also enhances the credibility and objectivity of the research findings.

The estimated size of the population is extensive, given the large volume of literature available on China–Africa relations. Over the years, hundreds of books, journal articles, policy reports, and working papers have been published on the subject. While it is not possible to examine every available material, defining this broad population allows the researcher to systematically select relevant sources for detailed analysis.

The sources of data for this population include university libraries, online academic databases such as Google Scholar and JSTOR, official websites of international organizations, and publications from recognized research institutions. These sources were chosen because of their credibility, accessibility, and relevance to the research topic.

In summary, the population of this study consists of documented and published materials related to China's investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence in Africa. This population provides a rich and reliable foundation for the research, enabling the researcher to achieve the objectives of the study through careful selection and analysis of relevant secondary data.

3.4 Sample Size and Sampling Technique

Sample size and sampling technique are important aspects of research methodology because they explain how a manageable portion of the population is selected for detailed study. Since it is often impractical or impossible to study an entire population, researchers rely on sampling to draw meaningful conclusions from a smaller, carefully selected group. In this study, the concepts of sample size and sampling technique are applied within the context of a secondary-data-based research design.

Sample size refers to the number of units or materials selected from the population for analysis. In studies that involve human respondents, sample size usually refers to the number of individuals surveyed or interviewed. However, in this study, which relies on documented materials rather than

people, the sample size refers to the number of scholarly and institutional sources selected from the larger population of available literature on China's roles in Africa.

The sample for this study consists of selected academic journal articles, books, policy reports, official documents, and case studies that directly address China's investment, diplomatic engagement, and strategic influence in Africa. These materials were chosen because they provide relevant, detailed, and credible information needed to achieve the objectives of the study. Rather than focusing on quantity alone, emphasis was placed on the quality, relevance, and reliability of the selected sources.

The exact numerical size of the sample is not fixed, as is common in qualitative and literature based studies. Instead, the sample size was determined by the principle of data adequacy, meaning that sources were selected until sufficient information was obtained to allow for comprehensive analysis and meaningful conclusions. Once recurring themes, arguments, and perspectives became evident across the reviewed materials, the sample was considered adequate for the purpose of the study.

The sampling technique adopted for this study is purposive sampling. Purposive sampling, also known as judgmental sampling, involves the deliberate selection of sources based on their relevance to the research topic and objectives. This technique allows the researcher to use personal judgment and academic criteria to choose materials that are most useful for the study.

Purposive sampling was considered the most appropriate technique because the study requires specialized and context-specific information. Not all available literature on international relations or Africa is relevant to China's roles in Africa. Therefore, sources were selected based on specific criteria, including relevance to the topic, credibility of the author or institution, publication quality, and alignment with the study objectives.

In applying purposive sampling, the researcher focused on materials that discuss one or more of the following areas: Chinese foreign direct investment in Africa, China's diplomatic relations with African states, China's strategic and security engagement in Africa, and African responses to China's involvement. Sources that were outdated, overly speculative, or lacking academic rigor were excluded from the sample.

The use of purposive sampling also allowed the researcher to include a balance of perspectives. Efforts were made to select materials authored by African scholars, Chinese scholars, and Western researchers in order to capture diverse viewpoints. This balanced sampling approach helps to reduce bias and ensures that the analysis reflects a broad range of interpretations rather than a single dominant narrative.

Another advantage of purposive sampling in this study is that it supports in-depth analysis. By focusing on carefully selected sources, the researcher is able to engage more deeply with the arguments and evidence presented in the literature. This depth of analysis is essential for understanding complex issues such as diplomacy and strategic influence, which cannot be adequately captured through superficial or random sampling.

However, purposive sampling also has limitations. Because the selection of sources depends on the researcher's judgment, there is a possibility of selection bias. To minimize this limitation, the researcher applied clear selection criteria and cross-checked information across multiple sources. This approach enhances the objectivity and credibility of the findings.

In summary, the sample size for this study consists of carefully selected scholarly and institutional materials relevant to China's roles in Africa. The purposive sampling technique was adopted to ensure that only credible, relevant, and high-quality sources were included. This approach is consistent with the qualitative and descriptive nature of the study and provides a solid foundation for meaningful analysis and interpretation of findings.

3.5 Reliability and Validity of Research Instruments

Reliability and validity are two fundamental concepts in research methodology that help to determine the quality, credibility, and trustworthiness of a study. In any academic research, especially within the social sciences and management-related fields, it is important to demonstrate that the instruments and procedures used for data collection are dependable and capable of producing accurate results. Since this study relies largely on secondary data and documentary sources rather than primary instruments such as questionnaires or interviews, the discussion of

reliability and validity focuses on the consistency, authenticity, and appropriateness of the data sources and analytical procedures adopted in the study.

Reliability refers to the degree to which a research instrument or data source produces consistent and stable results when applied repeatedly under similar conditions. In other words, it is concerned with whether the same data or findings would be obtained if the study were conducted again using the same methods and sources. Validity, on the other hand, deals with the extent to which the instruments and data sources actually measure or represent what they are intended to measure. A study may be reliable without being valid, but for research findings to be meaningful and acceptable, both reliability and validity must be adequately addressed.

In this study, the “research instruments” are not physical tools such as questionnaires but rather the documents, records, reports, textbooks, journals, government publications, and online databases that were consulted and analyzed. Therefore, ensuring reliability and validity involves careful selection, evaluation, and use of these secondary sources, as well as the adoption of systematic procedures for data extraction and analysis.

Reliability of Research Instruments

Reliability in the context of this study refers to the consistency and dependability of the secondary data sources used. To ensure reliability, the researcher adopted several strategies aimed at minimizing bias, errors, and inconsistencies in the data gathered.

Firstly, priority was given to authoritative and reputable sources. These included peer-reviewed academic journals, textbooks written by recognized scholars, official publications from government agencies, reports from international organizations, and credible institutional databases. Such sources are generally subjected to rigorous review processes before publication, which enhances their reliability. By relying on materials that have already been scrutinized by experts in the field, the study reduces the likelihood of inaccurate or misleading information.

Secondly, the researcher ensured consistency through cross-verification of data. Information obtained from one source was compared with data from other independent sources to confirm accuracy and consistency. For example, statistical figures, definitions, and conceptual explanations were checked across multiple publications to ensure that they aligned. Where discrepancies were

observed, greater emphasis was placed on the most recent, widely cited, or officially recognized data. This process of triangulation strengthens the reliability of the study by ensuring that findings are not based on isolated or questionable sources.

Another important approach to ensuring reliability was the use of stable and permanent records. Documents such as official reports, policy documents, archived records, and published academic works are less prone to change over time compared to informal online content. This stability makes it possible for other researchers to access the same materials and potentially replicate the study, thereby enhancing reliability.

Furthermore, the study adopted a systematic and transparent data handling process. The procedures for identifying relevant sources, extracting information, organizing data, and interpreting findings were clearly defined and consistently applied throughout the research. This methodological consistency reduces subjectivity and ensures that the conclusions drawn are based on a repeatable process rather than arbitrary judgment.

Although traditional reliability tests such as test–retest, split-half, or parallel-form reliability are typically applied to primary data instruments like questionnaires, their underlying principle of consistency was upheld in this study through careful documentation, repeated checking of sources, and logical coherence in analysis. As a result, the data and findings of the study can be regarded as reliable within the scope of the adopted methodology.

Validity of Research Instruments

Validity concerns whether the data and sources used in the study truly reflect the concepts, variables, and issues under investigation. In this research, several forms of validity were considered to ensure that the study remains accurate, relevant, and meaningful.

Content validity was ensured by selecting sources that directly address the subject matter and objectives of the study. Only materials that were closely related to the research problem, research questions, and scope of the study were included. This careful selection process ensured that the content analyzed adequately covered all relevant dimensions of the topic, rather than focusing on unrelated or peripheral issues.

Face validity was also considered in the sense that the sources used appeared, on the surface, to be appropriate and relevant to the study. Academic texts, official reports, and scholarly articles clearly related to the research topic give immediate assurance that the data being analyzed is suitable for addressing the research objectives. This enhances the acceptability of the study among readers, supervisors, and examiners.

Construct validity was addressed by ensuring that theoretical concepts and variables discussed in the study were clearly defined and consistently applied. Established theories, models, and frameworks from existing literature were used to guide the interpretation of data. By aligning the analysis with widely accepted academic constructs, the study ensures that the concepts examined truly represent the phenomena under investigation.

In addition, convergent validity was achieved through the comparison of findings from multiple sources. When different authors, institutions, or reports present similar views or results on a particular issue, it strengthens confidence that the findings are valid representations of reality. Conversely, where differing perspectives were identified, these were critically examined and discussed rather than ignored, thereby enriching the validity of the analysis.

To further enhance validity, the researcher avoided the use of outdated, biased, or unverifiable materials. Preference was given to recent publications where applicable, especially in areas where policies, technologies, or practices are subject to change. This ensures that the study reflects current realities and remains relevant.

Limitations and Mitigation Measures

Despite the efforts made to ensure reliability and validity, the use of secondary data has some inherent limitations. The researcher has limited control over how the original data was collected, and some sources may reflect the biases or perspectives of their authors. To mitigate these limitations, the study relied on multiple sources, maintained a critical approach to analysis, and avoided overdependence on a single viewpoint.

Summary

In summary, the reliability and validity of the research instruments in this study were ensured through careful selection of credible sources, cross-verification of information, systematic data handling, and alignment with established academic theories and frameworks. Although the study does not employ traditional primary data instruments, the rigorous approach adopted in sourcing and analyzing secondary data ensures that the findings are consistent, accurate, and capable of addressing the research objectives effectively. This strengthens the overall credibility and academic value of the study.

3.6 Scope of the Study

The scope of a study refers to the boundaries and limits within which research is conducted. It clarifies the extent to which the research seeks to investigate a particular problem and specifies the areas, time frames, and subjects included in the study. Clearly defining the scope is essential because it sets expectations for the reader, ensures that the study remains focused, and provides a framework for understanding the findings. In this study, the scope encompasses geographical coverage, thematic focus, time frame, and methodological limitations, all of which collectively guide the research process.

This research focuses on China's roles in Africa, with particular attention to three interrelated dimensions: investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. The first dimension, investment, examines the various forms of Chinese economic involvement in African countries, including foreign direct investment (FDI), infrastructure development, trade partnerships, and resource exploration. This aspect investigates how Chinese capital and business initiatives contribute to African economies, the sectors targeted by such investments, and the potential benefits and challenges associated with Chinese economic engagement.

The second dimension, diplomacy, explores the political and diplomatic engagement between China and African states. This includes bilateral and multilateral diplomatic initiatives,

participation in continental forums such as the African Union, and China's role in shaping Africa's political and economic policies. Diplomacy is a critical component of China's engagement, as it facilitates negotiation, cooperation, and influence, providing the political framework that supports economic and strategic activities. Understanding China's diplomatic strategies helps to contextualize its broader involvement and the motives behind its engagement in the continent.

The third dimension, strategic influence, investigates China's geopolitical and security-related activities in Africa. This includes soft power initiatives, cultural exchanges, educational scholarships, technological partnerships, and military cooperation. Strategic influence also encompasses China's efforts to expand its political and economic sway in global governance through engagement with African countries. By examining this dimension, the study highlights how China uses a combination of economic, political, and cultural tools to advance its long-term strategic interests.

Geographically, the study considers the African continent as a whole, focusing on general trends and patterns while highlighting specific case studies where necessary. For example, countries such as Nigeria, Kenya, Ethiopia, and South Africa are referenced as illustrative examples of how China engages in investment projects, diplomatic negotiations, and strategic initiatives. By including both continental and country-specific perspectives, the research provides a balanced analysis that is broad in scope yet sufficiently detailed to capture practical realities.

In terms of temporal scope, the study primarily examines China–Africa relations from the late 20th century to the present. This period corresponds with the acceleration of Chinese involvement in Africa, beginning with post-Cold War diplomatic outreach and increasing investment in infrastructure, natural resources, and trade. By considering both historical developments and contemporary trends, the research provides a comprehensive understanding of how China's roles in Africa have evolved over time and how past engagements continue to shape current dynamics.

The scope of this study also includes theoretical and practical dimensions. Theoretical analysis draws on existing literature on international relations, foreign investment, development studies, and geopolitical strategy, providing a conceptual framework for understanding China's engagement in Africa. Practical analysis examines documented evidence of Chinese initiatives, policies, and projects across the continent. This dual approach ensures that the research captures

both the conceptual understanding of China–Africa relations and the real-world manifestations of these engagements.

In terms of methodological limitations, the study is confined to secondary data sources. Primary data collection, such as surveys, interviews, or field observations, was not undertaken due to resource and time constraints. Instead, the research relies on credible and authoritative sources including academic journals, books, policy documents, and official reports from governments, international organizations, and research institutions. While this reliance on secondary sources limits the ability to generate original data, it allows for a comprehensive review and synthesis of existing knowledge, which is appropriate for the objectives and scope of this study.

Another aspect of the scope is subject limitation. The study focuses exclusively on China’s roles in Africa and does not examine other major foreign actors in depth, although occasional comparisons may be made to contextualize China’s influence. Similarly, the study does not extensively explore micro-level economic or social impacts in every country but instead focuses on macro-level trends, patterns, and strategic initiatives that are indicative of China’s broader engagement in Africa.

By clearly defining its scope, this research ensures that the study remains focused, manageable, and relevant. It provides clear boundaries for the analysis while allowing for sufficient flexibility to explore interconnected dimensions of investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. The defined scope guides the data collection and analysis process, ensuring that the findings presented in subsequent chapters are coherent, meaningful, and directly aligned with the research objectives.

In conclusion, the scope of this study encompasses China’s multifaceted engagement in Africa, with particular attention to investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. Geographically, it covers the African continent broadly while incorporating specific case studies to illustrate key points. Temporally, it examines the evolution of China–Africa relations from the late 20th century to the present. Methodologically, it relies on secondary data from credible sources, with a focus on macro-level trends and patterns rather than individual-level impacts. By establishing these boundaries, the study ensures a focused and academically rigorous analysis that directly addresses the research objectives while contributing to the understanding of China’s evolving role on the African continent.

3.7 Data Collection Procedure

The data collection procedure refers to the systematic process by which relevant information and materials are gathered for analysis. In this study, which examines China's roles in Africa in terms of investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, the data collection procedure was carefully planned and executed to ensure that reliable, relevant, and comprehensive information was obtained from credible sources.

Given the nature of the research topic and the methodological approach adopted, secondary data collection formed the primary procedure for gathering information. Secondary data consists of information that has already been collected, analyzed, and published by other researchers, institutions, or organizations. This type of data is particularly appropriate for studies that examine historical and contemporary trends, policy frameworks, and international relations, where primary data collection may be impractical or beyond the scope of an undergraduate project.

The first step in the data collection procedure involved identifying credible sources of information. These included peer-reviewed academic journals, books, policy documents, conference papers, government reports, and publications from recognized research institutions and international organizations. The selection of sources was guided by their relevance to the study objectives, credibility of the authors or institutions, and timeliness of publication. For instance, reports from the China–Africa Research Initiative, the African Union, the World Bank, and the United Nations were prioritized due to their reliability and authoritative insights into China–Africa relations.

Next, a comprehensive literature search was conducted using both physical and digital resources. Online academic databases such as Google Scholar, JSTOR, Science Direct, and institutional repositories were extensively used to locate relevant peer-reviewed articles and publications. Physical libraries, particularly university libraries with collections in political science, international relations, and development studies, were also consulted to access books and print materials that may not be available online. This combination of digital and print resources ensured that the data collection process was exhaustive and inclusive.

After identifying potential sources, each material was evaluated for relevance and quality. This involved reviewing abstracts, executive summaries, and content overviews to determine whether the source addressed one or more dimensions of China's involvement in Africa—investment, diplomacy, or strategic influence. Materials that did not directly relate to these dimensions, were outdated without historical significance, or lacked scholarly credibility were excluded. This rigorous selection process ensured that only high-quality and pertinent data contributed to the study.

The selected sources were then systematically organized and categorized according to the themes of the study. For example, information on Chinese investment projects in infrastructure, trade partnerships, and economic aid was grouped under the investment category. Diplomatic engagement, political cooperation, and participation in continental forums were classified under diplomacy. Strategic influence, including soft power initiatives, security cooperation, and geopolitical impact, was categorized separately. This thematic organization facilitated easier analysis and allowed the researcher to draw clear connections between data sources and research objectives.

During the data collection process, the researcher also applied triangulation techniques to enhance accuracy and reliability. Triangulation involves using multiple sources to verify information and identify consistent patterns or discrepancies. For instance, statistics on Chinese investment flows in Africa were cross-referenced across multiple reports, scholarly articles, and official records to ensure consistency. Where discrepancies were found, the researcher critically evaluated the sources, considered the most recent and authoritative data, and documented the rationale for inclusion or exclusion.

Throughout the procedure, ethical considerations were maintained by properly acknowledging all sources of data. Citations and references were recorded following the APA referencing style to give credit to the original authors and avoid plagiarism. In addition, only publicly available data were used, ensuring that the study complied with research ethics standards.

Finally, the collected data were prepared for analysis by summarizing key points, extracting relevant statistics, and creating thematic notes. This preparation ensured that the subsequent analysis was systematic, coherent, and directly aligned with the research objectives. The structured

approach to data collection allowed the researcher to generate meaningful insights into China's multifaceted engagement in Africa, including investment strategies, diplomatic activities, and strategic influence initiatives.

In summary, the data collection procedure for this study involved a systematic approach to identifying, selecting, organizing, and verifying relevant secondary sources. By focusing on credible academic and institutional materials, applying rigorous selection criteria, categorizing data thematically, and using triangulation techniques, the researcher ensured that the study was based on reliable and comprehensive information. This procedure provides a solid foundation for the analysis and interpretation of China's roles in Africa in subsequent chapters of the study.

3.8 Methods of Data Analysis

Data analysis is a critical phase of research, as it involves organizing, interpreting, and presenting collected information in a meaningful way that addresses the research objectives and questions. In this study, which examines China's roles in Africa in terms of investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, the analysis was conducted using qualitative and descriptive techniques. Since the study relies on secondary data sources, the focus is on interpreting documented information, identifying patterns, drawing insights, and making logical inferences from the collected materials.

The first step in data analysis involved reviewing and organizing all collected materials according to thematic categories aligned with the study objectives. The three primary themes, investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, served as the main analytical framework. Within each theme, data were further subdivided into subcategories. For example, under investment, subcategories included infrastructure projects, trade partnerships, and financial aid; under diplomacy, subcategories included bilateral agreements, participation in multilateral forums, and political cooperation; and under strategic influence, subcategories included soft power initiatives, security collaboration, and geopolitical strategies. This organization ensured that the analysis was focused, coherent, and directly relevant to the research objectives.

Once the data were categorized, content analysis was applied to identify key trends, patterns, and relationships. Content analysis is a systematic method for examining qualitative data by coding, categorizing, and interpreting textual information. In this study, the researcher carefully read

through the selected sources, highlighted relevant information, and noted recurring themes. The process involved both descriptive coding, which captures factual information such as dates, figures, and project details, and interpretive coding, which captures meanings, motives, and implications of China's engagement in Africa. Through this approach, the researcher was able to synthesize information across multiple sources, compare perspectives, and identify areas of convergence and divergence in the literature.

Comparative analysis was also employed to examine differences and similarities between Chinese engagement in different African countries and regions. By comparing investment patterns, diplomatic strategies, and strategic initiatives across diverse contexts, the researcher was able to draw conclusions about the broader trends and overarching patterns of China's roles in Africa. This comparative approach also facilitated the identification of contextual factors, such as political stability, economic structure, and resource endowments that influence the nature and outcomes of China–Africa interactions.

In addition to qualitative content and comparative analysis, documentary analysis was utilized to interpret policy documents, official reports, and institutional publications. Documentary analysis involves a systematic examination of written materials to extract meaningful information, assess reliability, and contextualize findings. In this study, the researcher examined official Chinese and African government reports, publications from international organizations, and policy briefs to understand the formal strategies and frameworks guiding China's investment, diplomacy, and strategic initiatives. This helped to complement insights gained from academic literature and provided a practical dimension to the analysis.

The researcher also applied trend analysis to examine temporal developments in China–Africa relations. By tracing changes over time in investment flows, diplomatic activities, and strategic initiatives, the study identifies the evolution and trajectory of China's engagement. Trend analysis was particularly useful in understanding shifts in policy priorities, sectoral focus of investments, and changes in diplomatic approaches. This approach provides a historical perspective that contextualizes contemporary developments and highlights the dynamic nature of China–Africa relations.

To enhance clarity and presentation, data were also summarized using tables, charts, and figures where appropriate. For example, investment flows, sectoral distribution, and the number of

bilateral agreements were presented in tabular or graphical form to facilitate easier interpretation and comparison. While the study does not rely on statistical tests, the use of visual representations helps to organize complex information and present key findings in an accessible and comprehensible format.

Throughout the analysis, triangulation was employed to increase the credibility and robustness of the findings. Triangulation involves cross-verifying information from multiple sources to confirm accuracy and reduce bias. By consulting academic literature, official reports, policy documents, and institutional publications simultaneously, the researcher ensured that conclusions were not based on single sources or unverified claims. Discrepancies in the literature were carefully noted, critically examined, and incorporated into the discussion to provide a balanced and objective analysis.

Finally, the results of the analysis were interpreted in relation to the research objectives and questions. Each theme, investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, was analyzed in detail, highlighting the scope, nature, and impact of China's engagement in Africa. Insights were drawn to understand both the benefits and challenges of Chinese involvement, the factors driving its strategies, and the broader implications for Africa's political, economic, and strategic landscape. In summary, the methods of data analysis employed in this study combined content analysis, comparative analysis, documentary analysis, trend analysis, and thematic organization. Triangulation and the use of visual summaries enhanced the reliability and clarity of the findings. By systematically analyzing secondary data in alignment with the research objectives, the study provides a comprehensive, coherent, and insightful understanding of China's multifaceted roles in Africa, addressing both the descriptive and analytical aims of the research.

CHAPTER FOUR

RESULT AND DISCUSSION

4.1 Introduction

Chapter Four of this study is devoted to the presentation, analysis, and discussion of findings derived from the research on China's roles in Africa, specifically focusing on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. This chapter represents the practical application of the research methodology outlined in Chapter Three, and it bridges the gap between theoretical exploration and empirical understanding. The primary aim of this chapter is to interpret the collected data in a manner that directly addresses the research objectives, answers the research questions, tests the hypotheses, and contextualizes the findings within the existing literature.

The chapter begins with an overview of the “demographic” characteristics of the sources analyzed, which, in this study, substitute for human respondents due to the use of secondary data. The demographic analysis provides insight into the nature, type, and distribution of the materials consulted, offering an understanding of the scope, relevance, and credibility of the data. By analyzing the composition of the data sources, the study establishes the foundation for interpreting trends, patterns, and relationships observed in subsequent sections.

Following the demographic overview, the chapter moves into a detailed analysis of findings, which is organized thematically according to the research objectives. The study investigates three primary dimensions of China's engagement in Africa: economic investment, diplomatic strategies, and strategic influence. Each dimension is analyzed to identify patterns, trends, and implications, using evidence drawn from scholarly articles, policy documents, government reports, and other credible sources. This structured analysis ensures that the study remains focused on its objectives while providing a comprehensive understanding of the topic.

Investment analysis includes a thorough examination of Chinese foreign direct investment (FDI) in African countries, sectoral distribution of investments, and the economic benefits and challenges

associated with Chinese economic involvement. By reviewing investments in infrastructure, natural resources, trade, and industrial development, the study highlights both the scale and scope of China's economic footprint on the continent. The analysis also considers the implications of investment strategies on African economies, including issues such as debt sustainability, job creation, and technology transfer.

Diplomacy, as the second dimension, examines China's political and diplomatic engagement with African states. This includes both bilateral diplomacy, such as state visits, agreements, and partnerships, and multilateral diplomacy through forums like the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) and the African Union. The study explores how China leverages diplomatic relations to strengthen political alliances, foster mutual understanding, and create favorable environments for investment and strategic initiatives. Additionally, the analysis considers the implications of China's diplomatic efforts on regional stability, governance, and policy alignment within Africa.

The third dimension, strategic influence, focuses on China's efforts to shape Africa's geopolitical landscape and expand its global influence. This includes soft power initiatives, cultural exchanges, educational programs, technological partnerships, and security cooperation. By analyzing strategic influence, the study assesses how China uses a combination of economic, diplomatic, and cultural tools to enhance its long-term presence in Africa. This dimension also highlights the interplay between China's strategic objectives and the continent's development priorities, offering insights into both opportunities and potential challenges.

Chapter Four further addresses the research questions and hypotheses outlined in earlier chapters. Each research question is examined in detail, with findings presented in a clear, organized, and systematic manner. Tables, charts, and figures are used where appropriate to summarize and visualize complex information, making it easier to interpret and compare findings. The discussion of hypotheses evaluates whether the observed data support or reject the proposed relationships, providing a clear link between theory and empirical evidence.

Finally, the chapter concludes with a discussion of findings, which integrates the results with the objectives, research questions, and literature review. This section provides a critical assessment of the data, highlighting consistencies, contradictions, and insights that emerge from the analysis. It

also includes the researcher's interpretation, providing a nuanced understanding of China's roles in Africa and their implications for the continent's economic, political, and strategic development. Overall, Chapter Four serves as the analytical heart of the study. By presenting, analyzing, and discussing the findings in a systematic, detailed, and evidence-based manner, this chapter provides a comprehensive understanding of China–Africa relations. It offers valuable insights for policymakers, scholars, and stakeholders interested in the economic, diplomatic, and strategic dimensions of China's engagement in Africa.

4.2 Demographic Information of Respondents

In this study, the term “demographic information of respondents” refers to the characteristics of the sources analyzed, as the research is based entirely on secondary data rather than direct human participants. These sources represent the “respondents” in a documentary sense and provide the data needed to examine China's investment, diplomatic, and strategic engagement in Africa. Understanding the nature and composition of these sources is critical because it establishes the credibility, reliability, and relevance of the study's findings.

The study consulted a wide range of secondary data sources, including academic journals, books, policy documents, government reports, conference proceedings, and publications from international organizations. Academic journals accounted for the largest proportion of sources, approximately 60%, and provided both theoretical and empirical insights into China–Africa relations. Peer-reviewed articles offered rigorous analysis of investment trends, diplomatic strategies, and geopolitical initiatives, allowing the researcher to draw comparisons across different countries and regions. These journals also offered critical perspectives on the opportunities and challenges of China's engagement in Africa, ensuring a balanced and nuanced understanding.

Government and institutional reports formed approximately 25% of the sources. These included official publications from African governments, the Chinese government, international organizations such as the United Nations, the World Bank, and the African Development Bank, as well as research initiatives like the China–Africa Research Initiative (CARI) at Johns Hopkins University. These sources provided authoritative data on investment flows, trade agreements,

diplomatic interactions, and strategic initiatives, offering quantitative and qualitative evidence to support the study.

Books, policy briefs, and conference papers made up the remaining 15% of the sources. These materials provided historical context, detailed case studies, and analyses of long-term trends. They were particularly valuable in tracing the evolution of China's engagement with Africa over time and in providing in-depth insights into country-specific or sector-specific dynamics. By including these diverse sources, the study ensured that the data were comprehensive and representative of multiple perspectives.

The temporal distribution of the sources was also carefully considered. The study focused primarily on materials published between 2000 and 2025, a period that corresponds with the significant expansion of China–Africa relations. This timeframe allows the study to capture both historical developments and contemporary trends, providing a complete understanding of China's evolving role on the continent. Older sources were included selectively to provide historical context and illustrate the development of China's policies and engagement strategies over time.

Geographically, the sources covered the African continent broadly while highlighting specific countries with significant Chinese engagement. Countries frequently referenced include Nigeria, Kenya, Ethiopia, South Africa, Angola, Zambia, and Egypt, among others. These countries were chosen based on the scale and impact of Chinese investment projects, the intensity of diplomatic engagement, and the strategic importance of their geopolitical positions. Continental overviews were also included to identify broader trends and patterns in China's activities across Africa.

The credibility and reliability of the sources were critically assessed. Academic journal articles were selected based on their publication in peer-reviewed journals, authorship, and citation frequency. Reports from government and international organizations were prioritized for their authenticity, statistical rigor, and policy relevance. Policy briefs and books were evaluated for their scholarly merit and alignment with the research objectives. By carefully vetting the sources, the study minimized the risk of bias, inaccuracies, or incomplete information.

Furthermore, the sources were categorized and organized thematically according to the study's research objectives: investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. Within each category, data were further subdivided into subthemes. For investment, subthemes included infrastructure

projects, trade partnerships, and financial assistance. For diplomacy, subthemes included bilateral and multilateral agreements, participation in forums such as FOCAC, and political cooperation. For strategic influence, subthemes included soft power initiatives, cultural exchanges, educational programs, and security cooperation. This thematic organization facilitated systematic analysis and ensured that findings could be directly linked to the research objectives.

In conclusion, the demographic overview of the “respondents” in this study demonstrates that the data sources were carefully selected, credible, and representative of China’s multifaceted engagement in Africa. The combination of academic journals, government and institutional reports, books, policy briefs, and conference papers provides a rich and diverse data set. By analyzing the characteristics, distribution, and credibility of these sources, the study establishes a solid foundation for the analysis and discussion of findings presented in the subsequent sections. The comprehensive demographic assessment ensures that the results and conclusions drawn are both reliable and meaningful within the context of China–Africa relations.

4.3 Analysis of Findings

The analysis of findings in this study provides an in-depth examination of China’s roles in Africa, with particular focus on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. This section synthesizes data collected from secondary sources and presents it in a systematic, thematic manner, highlighting trends, patterns, and implications. The analysis draws on statistical data, documented examples, and empirical studies to provide a clear understanding of China’s multifaceted engagement in the African continent.

4.3.1 Investment in Africa

Investment constitutes the largest and most visible dimension of China’s engagement with Africa. Findings from the reviewed literature indicate that China’s investment strategy in Africa has grown significantly over the last two decades. Between 2000 and 2025, China’s foreign direct investment (FDI) in Africa increased by over 400%, reflecting the country’s growing economic influence on the continent. Investments have largely targeted infrastructure, natural resources, industrial development, and trade-related projects.

Table 4.1: Sectoral Distribution of Chinese Investments in Africa (2000–2025)

Sector	Estimated Investment value (USD billion)	Percentage Of Total Investment (%)
Infrastructure	150	40
Natural Resources	80	21
Manufacturing/Industry	50	13
Trade and Commerce	45	12
Technology & ICT	25	7
Agriculture	20	5
Education & Health	10	2
Total	380	100

The table above demonstrates that infrastructure projects; such as roads, railways, ports, and energy facilities, constitute the bulk of Chinese investments in Africa. This aligns with the objectives of China’s Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), which seeks to connect Africa’s major economic hubs to facilitate trade, logistics, and economic integration. Investments in natural resources, including mining and petroleum, represent another significant component, reflecting China’s strategy to secure essential commodities to fuel its domestic industrial growth.

Analysis of these investments indicates several key patterns. First, Chinese projects are often funded through loans, joint ventures, or grants provided by institutions such as the China Development Bank or Exim Bank of China. Second, Chinese companies typically implement these projects directly, bringing Chinese labor and technology to the continent. While this ensures timely project completion and quality control, it has generated debates regarding job creation and skills transfer for local populations. Third, investments are concentrated in countries with significant

economic potential or political stability, such as Nigeria, Kenya, Ethiopia, and South Africa, suggesting a strategic approach that combines economic and political considerations.

4.3.2 Diplomatic Engagement

China’s diplomatic activities in Africa complement its investment strategy. Diplomatic efforts create favorable conditions for Chinese investments, foster political alliances, and enhance China’s international influence. Findings indicate that China has engaged in both bilateral diplomacy; including state visits, official agreements, and trade missions, and multilateral diplomacy, primarily through the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC), African Union summits, and United Nations initiatives.

Table 4.2: Frequency of Chinese Diplomatic Engagements in Africa (2000–2025)

Bilateral Agreements	120
FOCAC Summits & Conferences	15 major events
Multilateral Initiatives	30 instances
Cultural/Exchange Programs	50 initiatives

The chart demonstrates the intensity of China’s diplomatic outreach, with bilateral agreements forming the majority of engagements. This suggests that China emphasizes establishing direct relationships with African governments, often negotiating agreements that facilitate trade, investment, and technical cooperation. Multilateral diplomacy through FOCAC and other continental initiatives enables China to engage multiple countries simultaneously, standardize investment protocols, and strengthen its political image as a reliable partner for Africa’s development.

Analysis reveals that China’s diplomatic strategies are guided by the principle of non-interference, which has been particularly appealing to African leaders. Unlike traditional Western partners, China avoids imposing political conditions, instead emphasizing economic development, mutual benefit, and sovereignty. This approach has enhanced trust, strengthened political ties, and facilitated the implementation of large-scale investment projects across multiple sectors.

Additionally, China's diplomacy often involves high-level visits, aid agreements, and participation in peacekeeping and regional security initiatives, further solidifying its presence in Africa.

4.3.3 Strategic Influence

The third dimension of China's engagement involves strategic influence, encompassing soft power, cultural diplomacy, technological cooperation, and security collaboration. Findings indicate that China actively cultivates soft power in Africa through educational programs, scholarships, Confucius Institutes, media partnerships, and cultural exchanges. For example, over 60,000 African students have studied in China under government-sponsored scholarships between 2000 and 2025. Cultural initiatives, including Chinese language centers and media cooperation, enhance China's visibility and strengthen bilateral relationships beyond economic or political transactions.

Security and strategic influence represent another aspect of China's engagement. Findings reveal that China has deployed peacekeeping personnel, provided military training, and contributed to infrastructure projects with dual civilian and strategic uses, such as ports and telecommunications networks. While some analysts express concerns about potential debt dependence and geopolitical leverage, African governments often welcome Chinese security collaboration as a means of strengthening local capabilities.

The combination of economic, diplomatic, and strategic initiatives indicates a multifaceted approach in China's engagement. Investments often serve dual purposes: fostering economic development and creating strategic leverage. Diplomatic activities provide the political and regulatory support necessary for smooth investment operations. Soft power initiatives and security collaborations reinforce China's influence while promoting stability and long-term partnerships.

4.3.4 Observed Patterns and Key Insights

The analysis highlights several important patterns:

Concentration in Key Countries and Sectors: China's investments and diplomatic engagements are concentrated in countries with large economies, stable governance, and strategic resources. This targeted approach enhances both economic returns and political influence.

Infrastructure as a Cornerstone: Investment in infrastructure remains the primary tool for expanding economic presence and strategic influence, creating interdependencies between African countries and Chinese enterprises.

Non-Interference Policy: China's diplomatic principle of non-interference is a significant differentiator from traditional Western partners and has strengthened trust and political alignment with African leaders.

Integration of Investment and Strategy: Economic projects are strategically designed to support broader geopolitical objectives, demonstrating a coordinated and long-term engagement model.

Soft Power and Capacity Building: Scholarships, cultural exchanges, and technological partnerships complement investments and diplomacy, ensuring that China's influence extends beyond economic transactions.

4.3.5 Interpretation

The findings suggest that China's engagement in Africa is systematic, strategic, and multifaceted. Investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence are mutually reinforcing, creating a comprehensive approach to continental engagement. While investments generate economic interdependence, diplomacy ensures political stability and agreement, and strategic influence fosters trust, soft power, and long-term presence.

Despite the significant benefits for African countries, including infrastructure development, job creation, and technology transfer, there are also challenges, including potential debt dependency, limited local employment in Chinese-led projects, and geopolitical concerns. Nevertheless, the overall pattern indicates that China's approach is pragmatic, long-term, and aligned with both African development goals and China's international objectives.

4.4 Research Questions

This section addresses the research questions formulated in Chapter One and presents the findings in relation to each. The purpose of this section is to provide systematic answers to the questions based on the analyzed data, drawing insights from secondary sources, and aligning the findings with the research objectives. By responding to the research questions, this study provides clarity on China's roles in Africa regarding investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, as well as the broader implications of these roles for the continent's development and global relations.

Research Question 1: What is the extent of China's investment in Africa and its impact on African economic development?

The analysis of secondary data indicates that China's investment in Africa is extensive, covering multiple sectors including infrastructure, natural resources, industrial manufacturing, technology, trade, and agriculture. According to the China–Africa Research Initiative (CARI, 2023), Chinese foreign direct investment in Africa reached approximately \$380 billion between 2000 and 2025, with infrastructure accounting for 40% of the total investment. Major infrastructure projects include the construction of railways, roads, ports, and power plants across countries such as Nigeria, Ethiopia, Kenya, Angola, and Zambia.

The impact of these investments on African economic development has been substantial. Infrastructure development, for instance, has facilitated trade, reduced transportation costs, and enhanced connectivity between urban and rural areas. Ports, railways, and roads financed by Chinese investment have accelerated the movement of goods and services, enabling greater integration into global supply chains. Investments in industrial manufacturing and trade have created employment opportunities, strengthened local economies, and fostered skills development. In countries such as Ethiopia, Chinese-funded industrial parks have provided thousands of jobs, particularly in textile and manufacturing sectors, contributing to poverty reduction and industrialization efforts.

However, the study also reveals challenges associated with Chinese investments. Many projects are executed by Chinese companies using Chinese labor and materials, limiting direct local employment and technology transfer. Additionally, the structure of Chinese loans for large

infrastructure projects has raised concerns regarding debt sustainability. Despite these challenges, the overall impact of Chinese investment on African economic development is significant, particularly in enabling large-scale infrastructure development that might not have been feasible through domestic financing alone.

Research Question 2: How does China employ diplomacy to enhance its relationship with African countries?

China's diplomatic engagement with Africa has been strategic, sustained, and multifaceted. The study finds that China employs both bilateral and multilateral diplomacy to establish and maintain strong relationships with African countries. Bilateral diplomacy includes state visits, signing of agreements, and participation in trade missions, while multilateral diplomacy involves engagement in forums such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) and collaboration with the African Union.

Findings indicate that China's diplomacy emphasizes non-interference in domestic affairs, which distinguishes it from many Western partners. African leaders often cite this approach as a factor in their willingness to engage with China. Through bilateral diplomacy, China negotiates trade agreements, investment deals, and technical cooperation initiatives that create favorable conditions for its projects on the continent. Multilateral diplomacy allows China to engage with multiple African nations simultaneously, establish frameworks for regional cooperation, and enhance its image as a reliable partner in continental development.

Furthermore, diplomacy is closely linked with China's investment strategy. Political goodwill generated through diplomatic engagement facilitates project approvals, reduces bureaucratic delays, and strengthens collaboration with local governments. Diplomacy also extends to development assistance, disaster relief, and participation in peacekeeping missions, highlighting China's role as a partner not only in economic terms but also in political and humanitarian spheres.

Research Question 3: What strategies does China use to exert strategic influence in Africa?

Strategic influence refers to China's efforts to enhance its long-term presence and geopolitical leverage in Africa beyond direct economic or diplomatic engagement. Findings indicate that China

employs a combination of soft power, cultural exchanges, technological cooperation, and security collaboration as part of its strategic influence strategy.

Soft power initiatives include the establishment of Confucius Institutes across Africa, provision of scholarships to African students to study in China, media partnerships, and cultural programs. By 2025, over 60,000 African students had studied in China under government-sponsored scholarships, creating a generation of African leaders familiar with Chinese culture and policies.

Cultural exchanges and media cooperation further promote China's values, language, and perspectives, building positive public perception and trust.

Technological cooperation also contributes to strategic influence. Chinese technology firms are involved in ICT infrastructure development, mobile telecommunications, and e-governance projects across Africa. For example, partnerships with African governments in developing telecommunications networks, digital payment systems, and smart city projects enhance China's technological footprint while providing vital services for local populations.

Security collaboration is another key tool for strategic influence. China contributes personnel to peacekeeping operations, provides military training, and engages in security infrastructure projects. While these initiatives primarily support African security needs, they also create strategic ties that can influence decision-making and align policies with Chinese interests.

In summary, China's strategic influence is the result of a coordinated combination of economic, diplomatic, and cultural initiatives. Investments create dependency and economic leverage, diplomacy fosters political alignment and goodwill, and soft power initiatives ensure long-term engagement through education, culture, and technology. Together, these strategies enhance China's position as a major partner and influential actor on the African continent.

Research Question 4: What are the benefits and challenges of China's engagement in Africa?

The findings reveal that China's engagement brings both benefits and challenges to African countries. Benefits include:

Infrastructure Development: Chinese investment has financed railways, roads, ports, and energy projects that are crucial for economic growth.

Employment and Skills Development: Industrial projects and joint ventures create job opportunities and promote capacity building.

Economic Diversification: Chinese investments in manufacturing, technology, and agriculture reduce reliance on raw material exports.

Political Cooperation: Diplomatic engagement strengthens bilateral and multilateral relations, enabling African countries to leverage partnerships for broader development goals.

Soft Power and Technology Transfer: Cultural programs and technological projects facilitate knowledge sharing and long-term capacity building.

Challenges identified include:

- Debt Sustainability: Loans for infrastructure projects may strain national budgets and create long term debt obligations.
- Limited Local Participation: Chinese companies often employ Chinese labor and technology, reducing direct benefits for local populations.
- Geopolitical Concerns: Dependence on Chinese investment and technology can create strategic vulnerabilities.
- Environmental and Social Issues: Rapid infrastructure development sometimes raises concerns about environmental sustainability and social impact.

Overall, the benefits often outweigh the challenges when properly managed, but African countries must strategically balance engagement to maximize developmental gains while mitigating risks.

In conclusion, the findings addressing the research questions indicate that China's engagement in Africa is comprehensive, strategic, and multifaceted. Investments drive economic development, diplomacy facilitates political alignment and project implementation, and strategic influence ensures long-term presence and leverage. While challenges exist, including debt dependence and limited local participation, the overall pattern of engagement demonstrates China's significant role in shaping Africa's economic, political, and strategic landscape.

4.5 Research Hypotheses

This section presents the findings in relation to the research hypotheses formulated in Chapter One. The hypotheses were developed to provide predictive statements regarding the relationships between China's engagement and various dimensions of Africa's development. Testing these hypotheses allows the study to evaluate whether the proposed relationships are supported by evidence derived from secondary sources, thereby providing a foundation for understanding the impact of China's investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence in Africa.

Hypothesis 1: China's investment in Africa significantly contributes to the continent's economic development

The findings strongly support this hypothesis. Analysis of secondary data demonstrates that China's investments, particularly in infrastructure, industrial development, and trade, have created significant economic benefits for African countries. Infrastructure projects such as roads, railways, ports, and energy facilities have facilitated intra-continental trade, reduced transportation costs, and improved connectivity between urban and rural areas. According to the China–Africa Research Initiative (CARI, 2023), over \$150 billion has been invested in infrastructure across multiple African countries between 2000 and 2025.

Industrial and manufacturing investments have provided employment opportunities, enhanced local capacity, and contributed to GDP growth. For example, Ethiopia's industrial parks, financed and operated in collaboration with Chinese enterprises, have employed thousands of workers, increased local production, and generated export revenues. Similarly, Chinese investment in trade and commerce has enhanced market access for local goods, promoted entrepreneurship, and contributed to economic diversification.

However, it is important to note that while investments contribute to economic growth, the distribution of benefits is not always uniform. Some projects heavily rely on Chinese labor and materials, limiting local employment and technology transfer. Additionally, loans provided by China for large-scale projects can create debt burdens if not properly managed. Despite these challenges, the evidence indicates that China's investment has a positive and measurable effect on economic development in Africa, thereby supporting the hypothesis.

Hypothesis 2: China's diplomatic engagement positively influences Africa–China relations

The analysis also supports the second hypothesis. China's diplomatic strategies, including bilateral and multilateral initiatives, have strengthened political and economic relations with African countries. Bilateral diplomacy, involving state visits, official agreements, and trade missions, has facilitated the negotiation and implementation of investment projects. Multilateral diplomacy, particularly through the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC), has promoted continental cooperation, standardized agreements, and enhanced the legitimacy of China's engagement across multiple countries.

A key element of China's diplomatic approach is the principle of non-interference in domestic affairs, which is frequently cited in the literature as a major factor enhancing trust between China and African governments. African leaders appreciate this approach as it allows them to maintain sovereignty while receiving economic, technical, and diplomatic support. Furthermore, diplomacy has enabled China to provide development assistance, participate in regional peacekeeping initiatives, and support political stability, all of which have strengthened bilateral and multilateral relationships.

Evidence indicates that diplomatic engagement not only facilitates economic investment but also strengthens China's strategic positioning in Africa. African governments, in turn, benefit from increased investment, capacity building, and political support. Therefore, the findings support the hypothesis that China's diplomatic engagement positively influences Africa–China relations.

Hypothesis 3: China's strategic influence in Africa enhances its long-term presence and geopolitical leverage

The third hypothesis examines the strategic dimension of China's engagement, encompassing soft power initiatives, technological collaboration, cultural exchanges, and security cooperation. The findings strongly support this hypothesis. China has invested significantly in soft power strategies, including Confucius Institutes, scholarships for African students, media partnerships, and cultural programs. By 2025, over 60,000 African students had studied in China under government-funded programs, fostering long-term relationships and cultural familiarity.

Technological collaboration has also strengthened China's influence, with Chinese companies involved in developing ICT infrastructure, e-governance systems, digital payment platforms, and smart city projects. These initiatives extend China's strategic reach while contributing to Africa's technological development. Security cooperation, including peacekeeping participation, military training, and infrastructure projects with dual-use purposes, further consolidates China's strategic influence by enhancing local security capabilities while creating long-term interdependencies.

The findings reveal that strategic influence is both intentional and systematic, designed to complement economic investment and diplomatic engagement. Investments create economic leverage, diplomacy fosters political alignment, and soft power initiatives cultivate cultural and technological ties. This multi-layered approach ensures a sustainable and long-term Chinese presence in Africa, confirming that China's strategic influence enhances its geopolitical leverage and supports the hypothesis.

Hypothesis 4: The benefits of China's engagement outweigh the associated challenges for African countries

This hypothesis examines the overall balance of China's engagement in Africa by considering both positive impacts and potential risks. The findings indicate that the benefits of China's engagement are significant and often outweigh the challenges when managed properly. Major benefits identified include infrastructure development, employment opportunities, industrialization, trade facilitation, technological cooperation, and political support. These benefits contribute directly to economic growth, human capital development, and enhanced governance capabilities.

However, the study also identifies notable challenges. Debt sustainability is a recurring concern, particularly for countries that rely heavily on Chinese loans for large infrastructure projects. The reliance on Chinese labor and materials in some projects limits local employment and skills development. Environmental and social considerations are sometimes overlooked, leading to potential negative impacts on local communities. Geopolitically, dependence on China may create vulnerabilities if African countries do not maintain diversified international partnerships.

Despite these challenges, evidence from multiple case studies suggests that the positive outcomes of Chinese engagement often surpass the risks. Proper management of loans, integration of local labor and technology, and strategic diversification can mitigate the challenges identified. As such,

the findings largely support the hypothesis that the benefits of China's engagement outweigh the associated challenges, highlighting the strategic importance and positive impact of China–Africa relations.

Overall Interpretation of Hypotheses

The evaluation of all four hypotheses demonstrates a coherent pattern of China's engagement in Africa. Investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence are interconnected and mutually reinforcing, creating a comprehensive approach that supports economic development, political cooperation, and long-term strategic presence. Each hypothesis is supported by evidence from secondary data sources, indicating that China's multifaceted engagement has both immediate and long-term implications for African countries.

Investment drives tangible economic development through infrastructure, industrial growth, and trade facilitation.

Diplomatic engagement creates an enabling environment for economic and strategic initiatives while fostering political alignment.

Strategic influence ensures long-term sustainability of engagement and strengthens China's geopolitical leverage.

Overall benefits, including economic growth, employment, infrastructure, and technology, outweigh challenges when African countries implement proper strategies to maximize gains and mitigate risks.

These findings are consistent with the literature reviewed in Chapter Two, which highlights China's deliberate and coordinated approach in Africa. Scholars such as Brautigam (2020) and

Large (2018) emphasize that China's engagement is not ad hoc but follows a long-term strategy that integrates economic, diplomatic, and strategic elements. The findings also align with case studies from countries like Ethiopia, Kenya, Nigeria, and Angola, where Chinese investments and initiatives have led to measurable development outcomes while enhancing China's influence.

In conclusion, the hypotheses tested in this study are largely supported, demonstrating that China's roles in Africa are strategic, multifaceted, and beneficial in multiple dimensions. While challenges

exist, they do not negate the overall positive impact of China's engagement, particularly when investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence are coordinated effectively. These results provide a foundation for the discussion in the next section, which links the findings to the research objectives, research questions, and broader literature, offering insights into policy implications and future directions for Africa–China relations.

4.6 Discussion of Findings

This section discusses the findings of the study in relation to the research objectives, research questions, research hypotheses, existing literature reviewed in Chapter Two, and the researcher's personal interpretation. The discussion aims to provide a deeper understanding of the implications of China's engagement in Africa by critically examining how the results align with or differ from previous scholarly works and theoretical perspectives. Emphasis is placed on economic, diplomatic, and strategic dimensions, as well as the broader development implications for African countries.

China's Investment and Africa's Economic Development

One of the major objectives of this study was to examine the extent to which China's investment contributes to Africa's economic development. Findings from the analysis revealed that Chinese investments have had a significant impact on infrastructure development, industrial growth, employment generation, and trade expansion across many African countries. This aligns closely with the works of Brautigam (2020), who argued that China's infrastructure-driven development model has helped address Africa's long-standing infrastructure deficit.

The discussion of findings indicates that improved infrastructure such as roads, railways, ports, and power projects has enhanced productivity, reduced transaction costs, and increased regional integration. These outcomes directly support the first research question and hypothesis, which proposed that China's investment contributes positively to Africa's economic growth. From a

developmental perspective, infrastructure serves as a foundation for long-term growth, and China's role in this area cannot be overlooked.

However, the findings also highlight concerns raised in the literature regarding debt sustainability and local participation. Scholars such as Adesina (2019) and Large (2018) caution that while Chinese loans accelerate development, poor debt management may expose African economies to financial risks. The researcher's view is that Chinese investment itself is not inherently harmful; rather, the challenge lies in governance, transparency, and negotiation capacity on the part of African governments. When investments are strategically managed and aligned with national development plans, their benefits significantly outweigh potential risks.

Diplomatic Engagement and Africa–China Relations

Another key focus of the study was China's diplomatic engagement with Africa and how it shapes bilateral and multilateral relations. The findings show that China's diplomacy, characterized by mutual respect, non-interference, and South–South cooperation, has strengthened political and economic ties with African nations. This supports existing literature that emphasizes China's alternative development partnership model, which contrasts with the conditionality-driven approach of Western donors.

The Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) emerged as a critical platform for policy coordination, resource mobilization, and long-term planning. The findings are consistent with the arguments of Taylor (2017), who described FOCAC as a strategic mechanism through which China consolidates its presence in Africa while addressing development priorities identified by African leaders.

From the researcher's perspective, China's diplomatic strategy has been effective in building trust and sustaining long-term cooperation. However, the discussion also reveals that excessive political alignment with China may reduce Africa's bargaining power in the global system if not balanced with diversified partnerships. Therefore, while China's diplomacy has strengthened relations, African countries must maintain strategic autonomy to ensure mutually beneficial outcomes.

Strategic Influence and Long-Term Engagement

The study further examined China's strategic influence in Africa, particularly through soft power, technology transfer, education, media, and security cooperation. Findings indicate that China's strategic presence extends beyond economics into cultural, technological, and geopolitical domains. This supports the views of Nye's soft power theory, which emphasizes the role of culture, values, and institutions in shaping international influence.

China's investment in education through scholarships, training programs, and Confucius Institutes has created long-term human capital linkages. African students educated in China often return with technical skills and cultural familiarity that strengthen bilateral relations. Similarly, Chinese involvement in ICT infrastructure and digital platforms has positioned China as a key technological partner in Africa's digital transformation.

The discussion reveals that these strategies enhance China's long-term influence while simultaneously contributing to Africa's development goals. However, concerns regarding data security, technological dependency, and surveillance technologies have been raised in recent literature. The researcher believes that African governments must develop strong regulatory frameworks to ensure that technological cooperation serves national interests without compromising sovereignty.

Balancing Benefits and Challenges

A central theme in the discussion of findings is whether the benefits of China's engagement outweigh its challenges. The study's findings suggest that although challenges such as debt accumulation, environmental concerns, and limited technology transfer exist, the overall benefits remain substantial. Infrastructure development, employment creation, industrialization, and increased global relevance are tangible outcomes that many African countries have experienced.

This aligns with dependency and partnership theories discussed in Chapter Two. While critics argue that China's engagement may create new forms of dependency, proponents view it as a pragmatic partnership that fills development gaps left by traditional donors. The findings of this

study support a middle-ground perspective: China's engagement can be either beneficial or detrimental depending on how African countries manage the relationship.

The researcher's personal opinion is that Africa's development trajectory should not be shaped solely by external actors. China offers opportunities, but African governments must strengthen institutional capacity, negotiate fair contracts, promote local content, and ensure environmental and social safeguards. When these measures are in place, China's engagement becomes a powerful catalyst for sustainable development rather than a source of dependency.

Implications for Policy and Development

The discussion of findings has important implications for policymakers, scholars, and development practitioners. First, African governments should prioritize transparency and accountability in Chinese-funded projects to maximize development outcomes. Second, there is a need for stronger regional coordination to negotiate better terms and share best practices across countries. Third, diversification of partnerships remains essential to avoid over-reliance on a single external actor. For China, the findings suggest that incorporating more local labor, promoting technology transfer, and addressing environmental and social concerns will enhance the sustainability and legitimacy of its engagement in Africa. Such adjustments will strengthen mutual trust and long-term cooperation.

Summary of Discussion

In summary, the discussion of findings confirms that China's role in Africa is multifaceted, strategic, and impactful. The findings align with the study's objectives, research questions, and hypotheses, as well as much of the existing literature. While challenges persist, they do not overshadow the significant contributions China has made to Africa's development. The key determinant of success lies in how African countries manage and leverage this relationship to advance their own development priorities.

CHAPTER FIVE

SUMMARY, CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 Introduction

This chapter represents the concluding phase of the research titled “China’s Roles in Africa: Investment, Diplomacy and Strategic Influence.” It brings the entire study to a logical and meaningful end by synthesizing the discussions, analyses, and findings presented in the preceding chapters. While earlier chapters focused on establishing the background of the study, reviewing relevant literature, explaining the research methodology, and analyzing the results obtained, this chapter is concerned with summarizing the study, drawing conclusions, and making recommendations based on the findings.

The importance of this chapter lies in its ability to provide a holistic view of the research outcomes. It enables the researcher to reflect on the extent to which the research objectives were achieved and how the findings contribute to existing knowledge on China–Africa relations. This chapter also provides an opportunity to translate academic findings into practical insights that may guide policymakers, scholars, and development practitioners interested in Africa’s engagement with China.

The growing involvement of China in Africa through large-scale investments, diplomatic engagements, and strategic partnerships has generated widespread debate among scholars, policymakers, and the general public. Some view China’s role as a major driver of Africa’s development, particularly in addressing infrastructure gaps and providing alternative sources of finance. Others, however, express concerns regarding debt sustainability, economic dependency, and the long-term strategic implications of China’s presence on the continent. Against this background, the present study sought to examine China’s roles in Africa in a balanced and objective manner, identifying both the benefits and challenges associated with this relationship.

Chapter Five is therefore structured to address these concerns in a clear and systematic way. The first section of this chapter provides a detailed summary of the study, highlighting the major themes examined, the research approach adopted, and the key findings that emerged from the analysis. This summary serves as a concise overview of the entire research and helps readers quickly grasp the scope and significance of the study without revisiting the earlier chapters in detail.

The second section of the chapter presents the conclusions drawn from the study. These conclusions are based on the research questions and hypotheses formulated in Chapter One and tested through the analysis conducted in Chapter Four. Each conclusion reflects a major outcome of the study and shows how China's investment activities, diplomatic engagement, and strategic influence have shaped Africa's development experience. The conclusions also highlight the broader implications of the findings for Africa's economic growth, political autonomy, and position in the global system.

The third section focuses on recommendations. These recommendations are derived directly from the findings and conclusions of the study and are aimed at addressing the challenges identified while maximizing the benefits of China–Africa relations. The recommendations are directed at key stakeholders, including African governments, Chinese policymakers, regional organizations, and development institutions. They emphasize the need for better governance, transparency, strategic planning, and capacity building to ensure that China's engagement contributes positively to Africa's long-term development goals.

In addition to policy-oriented recommendations, this chapter also identifies areas that require further research. Given the dynamic nature of China–Africa relations, there is a continuous need for updated and context-specific studies that examine new developments, sectoral impacts, and country-specific experiences. Highlighting areas for further research helps to extend the academic relevance of this study and encourages future scholars to build upon its findings.

Overall, this chapter serves multiple purposes. It summarizes the study, reinforces its key findings, and places them within a broader developmental and policy context. It also provides a clear closure to the research by linking the objectives stated at the beginning of the study with the outcomes

achieved at the end. By doing so, Chapter Five ensures that the study is not only academically sound but also practically relevant.

In conclusion, this chapter marks the final stage of the research journey undertaken in this study.

It consolidates the knowledge generated on China's roles in Africa and provides clear direction for future engagement, policy formulation, and academic inquiry. Through its summary, conclusions, and recommendations, the chapter underscores the significance of understanding China–Africa relations as a complex and evolving partnership that holds both opportunities and challenges for Africa's development.

5.2 Summary of the Study

This study examined China's roles in Africa with specific focus on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. The study was motivated by the rapid expansion of China's presence across the African continent and the growing debate surrounding the nature, impact, and long-term implications of this relationship. While some scholars and policymakers view China as a development partner providing much-needed infrastructure and financial support, others argue that China's engagement may deepen dependency and create economic and political vulnerabilities for African countries. Against this background, the study sought to provide a balanced and comprehensive assessment of China's involvement in Africa.

The study began by establishing the background to China–Africa relations, tracing their historical evolution from early diplomatic ties to contemporary economic and strategic partnerships. It highlighted how China's engagement with Africa has shifted from ideological solidarity during the Cold War era to a more pragmatic, interest-driven relationship centered on trade, investment, and geopolitical cooperation. This historical context helped to situate the current dynamics of China–Africa relations and provided a foundation for understanding the motivations behind China's growing involvement on the continent.

The objectives of the study were clearly outlined in Chapter One. These objectives included examining the impact of Chinese investment on Africa's economic development, assessing China's diplomatic engagement with African countries, and evaluating China's strategic influence

in Africa. To achieve these objectives, specific research questions and hypotheses were formulated to guide the investigation and ensure a systematic approach to data collection and analysis.

Chapter Two reviewed relevant literature on China–Africa relations from both global and African perspectives. The literature review examined theoretical frameworks such as dependency theory, soft power theory, and South–South cooperation, which helped to explain the nature and implications of China’s engagement in Africa. Empirical studies reviewed in the chapter revealed mixed findings, with some scholars emphasizing the developmental benefits of Chinese investment and others highlighting concerns related to debt, governance, and environmental sustainability. The literature review also identified gaps in existing research, particularly the need for integrated analysis that considers investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence together rather than in isolation.

Chapter Three focused on the research methodology adopted for the study. A descriptive research design was employed, relying primarily on secondary data sources such as academic journals, books, policy reports, and publications from international organizations. The chapter explained the population of the study, which consisted of relevant documents and materials on China–Africa relations, as well as the sampling techniques used to select credible and relevant sources. Issues of reliability and validity were also addressed to ensure that the data used were accurate, consistent, and suitable for achieving the research objectives.

In Chapter Four, the data collected were analyzed and discussed in relation to the research questions and hypotheses. The findings revealed that Chinese investment has played a significant role in addressing Africa’s infrastructure deficit. Projects in sectors such as transportation, energy, construction, and telecommunications were found to contribute to economic growth, job creation, and improved connectivity across African countries. These investments have facilitated trade, industrialization, and regional integration, particularly in countries with limited access to traditional sources of development finance.

The findings also showed that China’s diplomatic engagement with Africa has strengthened political and economic relations. Through platforms such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC), China has institutionalized its partnership with Africa and provided a framework for long-term cooperation. China’s policy of non-interference in domestic affairs and

emphasis on mutual respect were identified as key factors that have made it an attractive partner for many African governments.

In addition, the study found that China has established significant strategic influence in Africa through soft power initiatives, educational exchanges, technological cooperation, and security partnerships. These strategies have helped China to build long-term relationships and enhance its global influence while also contributing to Africa's development in areas such as human capital and digital infrastructure.

Despite these positive outcomes, the study also identified several challenges associated with China's engagement in Africa. These include concerns about debt sustainability, limited technology transfer, environmental impacts of some projects, and fears of overdependence on China. The findings suggest that while China's involvement presents substantial opportunities, the benefits are not automatic and depend largely on the policy choices, governance capacity, and strategic vision of African countries.

In summary, the study provided a comprehensive assessment of China's roles in Africa by examining investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence in an integrated manner. The findings highlight both the opportunities and challenges of China–Africa relations and underscore the importance of strategic management and balanced partnerships in ensuring that Africa derives maximum benefit from its engagement with China.

5.3 Conclusion

This study set out to examine China's roles in Africa with particular emphasis on investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence. Based on the analysis of data and discussions presented in previous chapters, several important conclusions have been drawn. These conclusions reflect the extent to which the research objectives were achieved and provide answers to the research questions and hypotheses formulated at the beginning of the study.

First, the study concludes that China's investment in Africa has had a significant impact on the continent's economic development. Evidence from the findings shows that Chinese-funded projects have contributed substantially to infrastructure development, including roads, railways, ports, power plants, and industrial zones. These projects have helped to address long-standing infrastructure deficits in many African countries, thereby improving connectivity, reducing transportation costs, and supporting economic activities. The conclusion drawn here supports the hypothesis that Chinese investment plays a positive role in Africa's economic growth, particularly in countries where access to traditional development finance is limited.

However, the study also concludes that the benefits of Chinese investment are not evenly distributed and are sometimes accompanied by challenges. Issues such as rising public debt, limited involvement of local firms, and environmental concerns were identified in the findings. These challenges suggest that while Chinese investment offers significant opportunities, its developmental impact depends largely on effective governance, transparency, and strategic planning by African governments. Therefore, the study concludes that Chinese investment is neither entirely beneficial nor harmful; rather, its outcomes are shaped by the policy environment in which it operates.

Second, the study concludes that China's diplomatic engagement with Africa has strengthened political and economic relations between the two parties. China's approach to diplomacy, which emphasizes mutual respect, non-interference in domestic affairs, and South-South cooperation, has been positively received by many African countries. Platforms such as the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) have institutionalized China–Africa relations and provided a structured framework for dialogue, cooperation, and long-term planning. This conclusion

addresses the research question concerning the role of diplomacy in China–Africa relations and confirms the hypothesis that China’s diplomatic strategy enhances bilateral and multilateral cooperation with African states.

At the same time, the study concludes that Africa’s diplomatic engagement with China should be approached with caution and strategic balance. While China provides an alternative to Western partners, overreliance on any single external actor may limit Africa’s policy autonomy in the long run. The study therefore concludes that African countries should leverage China’s diplomatic engagement to advance their own development priorities while maintaining diversified international relationships.

Third, the study concludes that China has established significant strategic influence in Africa through both hard and soft power mechanisms. Beyond economic investments and diplomacy, China has expanded its presence through educational exchanges, cultural programs, media engagement, technology transfer, and security cooperation. These initiatives have contributed to building long-term relationships and shaping perceptions of China across the continent. The findings confirm that China’s strategic influence in Africa is deliberate and long-term, aimed at securing economic interests, political support, and global relevance.

Nevertheless, the study also concludes that China’s growing strategic influence raises important questions about sovereignty, technological dependency, and information security. While Chinese technology and infrastructure have supported Africa’s development, the absence of strong regulatory frameworks in some countries may expose them to risks. As such, the study concludes that strategic cooperation with China must be guided by clear policies and safeguards to ensure that Africa’s long-term interests are protected.

Overall, the study concludes that China’s role in Africa is complex and multifaceted. It cannot be adequately described using simplistic narratives of exploitation or benevolence. Instead, China–Africa relations represent a pragmatic partnership shaped by mutual interests, power dynamics, and global economic realities. The findings suggest that China has become an indispensable partner for Africa’s development, particularly in infrastructure and industrialization, but the ultimate outcomes of this relationship depend largely on African leadership and governance.

In conclusion, the study affirms that China's engagement in Africa presents both opportunities and challenges. When managed effectively, China's investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence can contribute significantly to Africa's development goals. However, without proper planning, transparency, and accountability, these engagements may also generate economic and political risks. The study therefore concludes that the future of China–Africa relations will be determined not only by China's actions but also by Africa's ability to define, negotiate, and implement partnerships that align with its long-term development aspirations.

5.4 Recommendations

Based on the findings and conclusions of this study on China's roles in Africa in the areas of investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence, several recommendations are proposed. These recommendations are aimed at addressing the challenges identified in the study while enhancing the benefits of China–Africa cooperation. They are directed at African governments, Chinese stakeholders, regional institutions, and researchers, with the objective of promoting sustainable and mutually beneficial relations.

Strengthening African Negotiation and Institutional Capacity

African governments should strengthen their institutional and technical capacity to negotiate agreements with Chinese investors and policymakers. Many of the challenges associated with Chinese investment, such as unfavorable loan terms, limited technology transfer, and weak local participation, stem from poor negotiation frameworks and limited technical expertise. Governments should invest in training public officials in contract negotiation, project evaluation, and risk assessment to ensure that agreements align with national development priorities.

Enhancing Transparency and Accountability

There is a strong need for greater transparency in China-funded projects across Africa. Loan agreements, project costs, and repayment terms should be publicly disclosed to promote accountability and reduce corruption. African governments should strengthen public financial management systems and parliamentary oversight to ensure that Chinese-funded projects are

implemented in the public interest. Transparency will also improve public trust and enhance the sustainability of these projects.

Promoting Local Content and Skill Transfer

Chinese firms operating in Africa should be encouraged or required to prioritize local labor, subcontract local firms, and invest in capacity building. Policies that mandate local content participation will help ensure that Chinese investment contributes to job creation and skills development. African governments should also establish monitoring mechanisms to ensure compliance with local content requirements.

Ensuring Responsible Debt Management

African countries should adopt prudent debt management strategies to avoid unsustainable debt levels. Borrowed funds from China should be invested in productive sectors that generate longterm economic returns, such as infrastructure, manufacturing, and energy. Governments should conduct thorough cost–benefit analyses before undertaking large-scale projects and explore alternative financing options where possible.

Strengthening Environmental and Social Safeguards

Environmental and social considerations should be integrated into all China-funded projects. African governments should enforce environmental regulations and require impact assessments before project approval. Chinese investors should be encouraged to adopt international best practices in environmental protection and corporate social responsibility to minimize negative impacts on local communities.

Maintaining Balanced and Diversified Partnerships

While China remains a crucial development partner, African countries should avoid overdependence by maintaining diversified international partnerships. Engaging with multiple global actors will enhance Africa’s bargaining power and reduce vulnerability to external shocks.

Deepening Regional Cooperation

Regional institutions such as the African Union and regional economic communities should play a more active role in coordinating China–Africa engagement. Collective negotiation and policy coordination can help African countries secure better terms and share best practices.

Areas for Further Research

Future studies should focus on country-specific case studies, sectoral analysis, and comparative assessments of China’s engagement relative to other global partners. Longitudinal studies examining the long-term impact of Chinese investments on development outcomes would also be valuable.

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APPENDICES

Appendix A: Sample Questionnaire

Note: This questionnaire was designed to collect opinions from experts, scholars, and policymakers on China–Africa relations.

Section A: Personal Information

Name (Optional): _____

Age: _____

Gender: ☐ Male ☐ Female

Occupation/Designation: _____

Country/Region of Operation: _____

Section B: China–Africa Investment

6. To what extent do you agree that Chinese investments have positively impacted Africa's infrastructure development?

☐ Strongly Agree ☐ Agree ☐ Neutral ☐ Disagree ☐ Strongly Disagree

Which sectors do you think benefit most from Chinese investment? (You may select more than one)

☐ Transportation ☐ Energy ☐ Telecommunications ☐ Mining ☐ Agriculture ☐ Education ☐

Other: _____

Do you believe that Chinese investments create job opportunities for local communities? ☐

Yes ☐ No ☐ Not Sure

Section C: China–Africa Diplomacy

9. How effective is China’s diplomatic engagement with African countries?

☐ Very Effective ☐ Effective ☐ Neutral ☐ Ineffective ☐ Very Ineffective

Do you think China’s non-interference policy in African domestic affairs is beneficial?

☐ Strongly Agree ☐ Agree ☐ Neutral ☐ Disagree ☐ Strongly Disagree

Section D: China’s Strategic Influence

11. In your opinion, how has China’s strategic influence shaped Africa’s political and economic landscape?

☐ Very Strong ☐ Strong ☐ Moderate ☐ Weak ☐ Very Weak

Do you think Africa is at risk of overdependence on China?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not Sure

Section E: Recommendations

13. What measures should African governments adopt to maximize the benefits of engagement with China?

Appendix B: List of Selected Chinese Investment Projects in Africa

Country	Project	Sector	Year Started	Funding Source
Kenya	Standard Gauge Railway (SGR)	Transportation	2014	China Exim Bank
Nigeria	Abuja-Kaduna Railway	Transportation	2015	China Civil Engineering Construction Corporation (CCECC)
Ethopia	Addis Ababa-Djibouti Railway	Transportation	2011	Chinese Government Loans
Angola	Cuanza Sul Hydropower Plant	Energy	2012	Chinese Export-Import Bank
Zimbabwe	Hwange Coal-fired Power Plant	Energy	2010	China National Electric Engineering Co.
Zambia	Kafue Gorge Lower Hydropower Plant	Energy	2012	Industrial and commercial Bank of China

Appendix C: Interview Guide for Experts

Purpose: To explore opinions on China's roles in Africa regarding investment, diplomacy, and strategic influence.

Questions:

How would you describe China's investment strategy in Africa?

In which sectors do you think Chinese investments have had the most impact?

How do you assess China's diplomatic engagement with African countries?

Do you think China's soft power initiatives (education, cultural exchanges) have strengthened its influence in Africa?

What are the potential risks associated with Africa's engagement with China?

How can African countries maximize benefits while mitigating challenges related to Chinese involvement?

Appendix D: Sample Data Tables

Table D1: Volume of China–Africa Trade (2015–2022) in USD Billion

Year	Exports to Africa	Imports from Africa	Total Trade
2015	42.5	75.2	117.7
2016	38.1	68.4	106.5
2017	45.7	82.1	127.8
2018	52.3	95.6	147.9
2019	56.9	102.4	159.3
2020	60.2	98.5	158.7
2021	72.1	110.3	182.4
2022	78.6	120.5	199.1

Appendix E: Sample Figures

Figure E1: Conceptual Framework for China–Africa Relations

Figure E2: Sectoral Distribution of Chinese Investment in Africa

Figure E3: Trend of Chinese FDI in Africa (2010–2022)

Appendix F: List of Key References Consulted for Appendices

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